

Hindi, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Hindi one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Devanagari letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read नमस्ते and learn that it means “I bow to you” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already knows Devanagari simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Hindi’s depth comes from a double inheritance. Much of its core vocabulary is **Sanskrit** — नमस्ते and धन्यवाद sit on ancient roots (*nam*, “to bow”; *dhanya*, “worthy”). But centuries of Persian as the language of courts layered on a second vocabulary, Persian and (through it) Arabic — so “thanks” is also शुक्रिया (*shukriyā*, the same Semitic root as Arabic *shukran*), and “farewell” is अलविदा (*alvidā*, “the farewell,” carrying the Arabic article *al-*). The book keeps both streams in view.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Hindi out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is

gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Hindi greetings — and, taught through them, how to read Devanagari and Hindi’s double inheritance (Sanskrit and Perso-Arabic). Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C01-*.md.*

1.1 नमस्ते (*namaste*) — “I bow to you”

The letters in this word

Hindi reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न na, म ma, स sa, त ta. A vowel sign changes the vowel: े makes “e” (ते = te). A *halant* (the stroke under स्) *removes* the vowel, and the bare consonant leans onto the next as a **conjunct**: स् + ते → स्ते. Read left to right: न·म·स्·ते → *namaste*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्ते = नमः (*namaḥ*, “a bow, reverence,” from Sanskrit root नम् *nam*, “to bow”) + ते (*te*, “to you”) = literally “**I bow to you.**” The root *nam* also builds *namaskār* (next), and *namaste* is borrowed whole into English.

Why it’s said this way

A real gesture, not a bland “hi”: said with palms pressed together, in respect. Works as both hello and goodbye, any time, polite without being stiff.

1.2 नमस्कार (*namaskār*) — the more formal bow

The letters in this word

New: क ka, र ra, and the sign ा for long “ā” (का = kā). You already read नमस् (*namas*). न·म·स्·का·र → *namaskār*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कार = नमः (*namah*, “bow,” root *nam*) + कार (*kāra*, “the making/doing of,” from Sanskrit कृ *kr*, “to do”). Literally “the making of a bow.” That piece *-kāra* (“the act of _____”) recurs across Sanskrit vocabulary.

A notch more **formal** than *namaste* — ceremonial, or for elders and writing.

1.3 धन्यवाद (*dhanyavād*) — “thank you,” the Sanskrit way

The letters in this word

New: ध dha, य ya, व va, द da, and a new conjunct न् + य → न्य (“nya”). ध·न्·य·वा·द → *dhanyavād*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवाद = धन्य (*dhanya*, “worthy, blessed,” from धन *dhana*, “wealth”) + वाद (*vāda*, “a saying,” from Sanskrit वद् *vad*, “to speak”). Literally “an utterance of [you are] worthy” — a formal, literary “thanks.”

Why it’s said this way

The **formal, Sanskritic** “thank you” — written, official, respectful. For everyday thanks Hindi often reaches for a lighter Persian word, शुक्रिया — next — and holding the two together is the best window into Hindi.

1.4 शुक्रिया (*shukriyā*) — Hindi's other heritage

The letters in this word

New: श sha, and the sign ि for “i” (written *before* the consonant, read *after*). With a conjunct क् + र → क्र (“kra”): शु·क्·रि·या → *shukriyā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

शुक्रिया is *not* Sanskrit. It came through Persian from **Arabic** *shukr* (“gratitude”), root **sh-k-r** — the *same word* as Arabic *shukran*. Two unrelated languages, one Semitic root for thanks.

Why it's said this way

Centuries of Persian as the court language poured Persian and Arabic words into everyday Hindi/Urdu, so Hindi carries **two vocabularies**: Sanskrit (*dhanyavād*, *namaste*) and Perso-Arabic (*shukriyā*, *alvidā*). Often the Sanskrit word is formal and the Persian one everyday. *shukriyā* is the casual, everyday “thanks.”

1.5 अलविदा (*alvidā*) — “the farewell”

The letters in this word

New: the independent vowel अ (“a,” for a word that *starts* with a vowel) and ल la. अ·ल·वि·दा → *alvidā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अलविदा came through Persian from **Arabic** *al-widā'* (“the farewell”), root **w-d-'**. At the front is अल — the Arabic article **al-**, “the,” the same one riding inside English *algebra* and *alcohol*. So *alvidā* is literally “the farewell.”

Why it's said this way

Carries **finality** — the goodbye for a long or final parting. For casual “bye,” Hindi uses *namaste* again, or *phir milenge* (“we’ll meet again”).

Next chapter: *āp* vs. *tum* (formal and informal “you”), and introducing yourself.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

मेरा नाम मीरा है। (merā nām Mīra hai — “My name is Mira.”)
आपका नाम क्या है? (āpkā nām kyā hai — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C02-*.md.*

2.1 नाम (nām) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

Three letters, left to right: न (na), ा the long-ā mātrā (ना = nā), म (ma).
Read ना·म → nām.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाम (nām) ← Sanskrit नामन् (nāman), from Proto-Indo-European *h₃nómn. — the same ancient root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**, **nominate**), and Greek *onoma*. So Hindi *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed — one of the clearest bridges between the Indian and European branches of the same family.

2.2 मेरा (*merā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

म (*ma*) + े (the *e-mātrā*) → मे (*me*); then र (*ra*) + ा (long *ā*) → रा (*rā*).
Read मे-रा → *merā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मेरा (*merā*, “my”) descends from Sanskrit *mad-īya* (“of me”), on the first-person root *ma-* — the same *ma-/me-* behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *meus*. The Hindi “my” and the English “my” are, at the root, the same word.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees with the noun. Hindi possessives change to match what is owned: *merā* (masculine), *merī* (feminine), *mere* (plural). *nām* is masculine, so it takes *merā*: *merā nām*. (You will meet *merī* the first time you own a feminine noun.)

2.3 है (*hai*) — “is,” cousin of English *is*

The letters in this word

ह (*ha*) + ै (the *ai-mātrā*) → है (*hai*). One syllable.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

है (*hai*, “is”) ← Sanskrit अस्ति (*asti*, “is”), from Proto-Indo-European **h₁es-* — the root of “to be” across the whole family: English **is**, German *ist*, Latin *est*, Spanish *es*, French *est*. Hindi *hai* is the Indian cousin of the same little verb — “is” really is one word from Ireland to India.

2.4 मेरा नाम ...है (*merā nām ...hai*) — “my name is...”

मेरा (*my*) + नाम (*name*) + है (*is*) = **merā nām ...hai**, “my name is...” *Merā nām Arun hai.* = “My name is Arun.”

2.5. आप / तुम (ĀP / TUM) — “YOU,” RESPECTFUL AND FAMILIAR

Grammar Lens

Word order: the verb goes last. Hindi is a *subject-object-verb* language — literally “my name Arun *is*.” The *hai* sits at the end, where English puts “is” in the middle. Bank this shape: in Hindi, the verb waits until the end of the sentence.

2.5 आप / तुम (*āp* / *tum*) — “you,” respectful and familiar

The letters in this word

आप: the independent vowel आ (*ā*, word-initial) + प (*pa*) → *āp*. तुम: त (*ta*) + उ (the *u*-sign) + म (*ma*) → *tum*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

तुम (*tum*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE *tū — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*. आप (*āp*, respectful “you”) is a different, honorific word (originally “oneself”).

Grammar Lens

Three levels of “you.” Hindi grades respect in three: *āp* (respectful — strangers, elders, politeness), *tum* (familiar — friends, peers), *tū* (intimate or to a child, and can insult if misused). Each of the earlier tracks had two levels; Hindi has three. For a first meeting, always *āp*.

2.6 क्या (*kyā*) — “what”

The letters in this word

A **conjunct**: क (*ka*) loses its vowel (*halant*) and joins य (*ya*) → क्य (*kya*); add the long-*ā* mātrā → क्या (*kyā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

क्या (*kyā*, “what”) ← Sanskrit *kim* / the interrogative stem *ka-*, from PIE *k^wo- — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words (**what**,

who, which) and Latin *qu-*. Hindi’s question-words nearly all start with this *k-*: *kyā* (what), *kaun* (who), *kab* (when), *kyūn* (why) — the Indian branch of the same family of question-words.

2.7 आपका नाम क्या है? (*āpkā nām kyā hai*) — “what’s your name?”

आपका (*āpkā*, “your”) = आप (you) + का (*kā*, the possessive “of,” the same agreeing *kā/kī/ke* that matches the noun). So आपका नाम क्या है? is literally “**your name what is?**” — Hindi keeps the verb last again, and simply drops the question-word *kyā* into the object slot.

Grammar Lens

Answer it with the sentence you built: *Merā nām Arun hai*. The informal version swaps *āpkā* for *tumhārā*: *tumhārā nām kyā hai?*

2.8 खुशी (*khushī*) — “happiness,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The Hindi “pleased to meet you” is आपसे मिलकर खुशी हुई (*āp-se milkar khushī huī*) — literally “**having met you, happiness happened.**” The key word खुशी (*khushī*, “happiness”) is **not** Sanskrit — it is **Persian** (*khush*, “happy, pleasant”), one of the thousands of Persian words in everyday Hindi. So even introducing yourself draws on Hindi’s *two* vocabularies: Sanskrit (*nām*, *hai*) and Perso-Arabic (*khushī*).

2.9 The whole exchange

Hindi	English
मेरा नाम मीरा है।	My name is Mira.
आपका नाम क्या है?	What’s your name?
मेरा नाम अरुण है।	My name is Arun.
आपसे मिलकर खुशी हुई।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nām* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *merā* (root *ma-*, English *my*), *hai* (Sanskrit *asti*, English *is*), *kyā* (root *ka-*, English *what*). And two Hindi habits: the **verb goes last**, and “you” has **three** respect-levels. Next chapter: *āp kaise hai?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *thik* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — asking, and answering, how someone is:

आप कैसे हैं? (*āp kaise haiṃ* — “How are you?”)
मैं ठीक हूँ, धन्यवाद। (*maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ, dhanyavād* — “I’m fine, thank you.”)

Every atom traced, then assembled.

Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C03-.md.*

3.1 कैसे (*kaise*) — “how,” another of the k- questions

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + ै (the *ai-mātrā*) → कै (*kai*); स (*sa*) + े (the *e-mātrā*) → से (*se*). Read कै-से → *kaise*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कैसे (*kaise*, “how”) ← Sanskrit *kīdrśa* (“of what kind”) / the interrogative stem *ka-*, from Proto-Indo-European **k^wo-* — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words and Latin *qu-*. Hindi’s questions nearly all begin with this *k-*: *kyā* (what), *kaun* (who), *kab* (when), *kahāṃ* (where), *kaise* (how).

Grammar Lens

The adjective कैसा (*kaisā*) agrees: *kaisā* (m.), *kaisī* (f.), *kaise* (m. plural / respectful). Because the respectful “you” (*āp*) takes a plural verb, “how are *you*?” uses the plural कैसे.

3.2 आप कैसे हैं? (*āp kaise haiṃ*) — “how are you?”

हैं is है (*hai*, “is”) + the *anusvāra* ँ → हैं (*haiṃ*), the nasalised plural. So आप कैसे हैं? is literally “**you how are?**” — verb last, and because *āp* is grammatically plural (that is how Hindi shows respect), its verb is the plural *haiṃ*, not *hai*.

Grammar Lens

Respect is plural. To an elder or stranger: *āp kaise haiṃ?* To a friend: *tum kaise ho?* (*ho* is the familiar “are”). Match the “you” to the verb: *āp ... haiṃ*, *tum ... ho*.

3.3 मैं (*maiṃ*) — “I,” the m- of the first person**The letters in this word**

म (*ma*) + ैं (*ai*) + the *anusvāra* ँ → मैं (*maiṃ*). One nasal syllable.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मैं (*maiṃ*, “I”) ← Sanskrit *mayā* (“by me”), on the first-person root *ma* — the same root behind Chapter 2’s *merā* (“my”) and behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *mē*. Hindi’s “I,” its “my,” and English’s “me/my” grow from one ancient first-person sound.

3.4 हूँ (*hūṃ*) — “am,” cousin of English *am***The letters in this word**

ह (*ha*) + ूँ (long *u*) → हूँ (*hū*); the *chandrabinḍu* ँ nasalises → हूँ (*hūṃ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

हूँ (*hūṃ*, “am”) ← Sanskrit *asmi* (“I am”) — the first person of the root that also gave you *hai*. That root, PIE *h₁es-, is “to be” across the family: *asmi* → English **am**, Latin *sum*; *asti* → *hai* / English *is*. The copula lines up person by person: हूँ *am*, है *is*, हैं *are*.

3.5 ठीक (ṭhīk) — “fine,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ठ (*ṭha*, a **retroflex** *th* — tongue curled to the roof of the mouth) + ी (long *ī*) + क (*ka*) → ठीक. The retroflex ट-ठ-ड series is a hallmark of Indian sound.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ठीक (*ṭhīk*) means “correct, right, fine, exactly, OK.” It is a genuinely **native** Indian word — no European cousin — and one of the most useful in the language. Not every word has a far-flung cognate, and that is worth seeing too: *ṭhīk* is Indian to the core.

Put the atoms together: मैं ठीक हूँ (*maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ*) — “I am fine” (literally “I fine am”). The whole exchange:

— āp kaise haiṃ? — maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ, dhanyavād.

3.6 आपका स्वागत है (*āpkā svāgat hai*) — “you’re welcome”

The letters in this word

The key word स्वागत (*svāgat*): the conjunct स्व (स् *s* + व *va* → *sva*) + ग (*ga*) + त (*ta*), with आपका (*āpkā*, “your”) and है (*hai*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आपका स्वागत है = “your welcome is” → “**you are welcome.**” The heart, स्वागत (*svāgat*), is Sanskrit *su* (“well, good”) + *āgata* (“come”) — “**well come,**” exactly like English *welcome*. Inside it: *su-* the twin of Greek *eu-* (*euphoria*), and *āgata* from the root *gam* (“go/come”), cousin of English *come*. You will meet *svāgatam* again, unchanged, in the Sanskrit track.

3.7 The whole exchange

Hindi	English
आप कैसे हैं?	How are you?
मैं ठीक हूँ, धन्यवाद।	I’m fine, thank you.
आपका स्वागत है।	You’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *kaise* (the interrogative *k-*, English *how*), *maiṃ* (root *ma-*, English *me*), *hūṃ* (Sanskrit *asmi*, English *am*), *svāgat* (*su* + *āgata* = “well come”). You now hold the copula trio — *hūṃ* / *hai* / *haiṃ*. Next chapter: the farewells, from the formal *alvidā* to the warm *phir milenge*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the grave, formal अलविदा (*alvidā*). Real days end more warmly — with a promise to meet again:

फिर मिलेंगे! (*phir milenge* — “We’ll meet again!”)

Practice lessons: lessons/HI-CO4-.md.*

4.1 फिर (*phir*) — “again”

The letters in this word

फ (*pha*, an aspirated *p*) + ि (the *i*-mātrā, written before but read after) + र (*ra*) → फिर.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

फिर (*phir*) means “again, then, afterwards” — a native Indo-Aryan adverb with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar *job*: it turns a parting into a promise. English “see you *again*”; Hindi *phir milenge*.

4.2 मिलेंगे (*milenge*) — “(we) will meet”

The letters in this word

मि (*mi*) + ले (*le*) + the *anusvāra* + गे (*ge*) → मिलेंगे (*milenge*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मिलेंगे (*milenge*, “we will meet”) is the future of मिलना (*milnā*, “to meet, to be found”), from Sanskrit *mil-* (“to join, unite”) — the root of *milan* (“a meeting, union”). The ending -एंगे (*-enge*) is the plural future.

Grammar Lens

The future is an ending, not a helper. *mil-* (“meet”) + *-enge* (“we/they will”) → *milenge*. No word like English “will” — the tense lives in the ending, as person lives in *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ*.

4.3 फिर मिलेंगे (*phir milenge*) — “we’ll meet again”

फिर (again) + मिलेंगे (we will meet) = “we’ll meet again.” Where अलविदा (*alvidā*) is grave and final — and, fittingly, a Perso-Arabic word (*al-widā*, “the farewell”) — *phir milenge* is native, everyday, and hopeful, the sibling of the “promise of return” goodbyes across South Asia (Tamil, Bengali, Marathi all say “I’ll come again”).

Grammar Lens

Two registers: अलविदा (formal, final, Perso-Arabic) versus फिर मिलेंगे (everyday, warm, native). Even more casual: *phir milte haiṃ* (“(we) meet again,” present for a near future).

4.4 कल मिलते हैं (*kal milte haiṃ*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + ल (*la*) → कल (*kal*). Two simple letters, one tricky word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कल (*kal*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit *kāla* (“time”), the very root behind Punjabi’s *akāl* (“timeless”). Context and the verb’s tense tell which: *kal milte haiṃ* (“tomorrow”), *kal milā* (“yesterday”).

Grammar Lens

मिलते हैं (*milte haiṁ*) is literally “(we) meet” — Hindi, like English (“I’m seeing you tomorrow”), uses the present for a scheduled future.

4.5 चलता हूँ (*caltā hūṁ*) — “I’ll be off”**The letters in this word**

च (*ca*) + ल (*la*) + long *ā* → चलता (*caltā*), with हूँ (*hūṁ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

चलता हूँ literally “**I go / I move**” — used like English “I’ll be off.” The verb चलना (*calnā*, “to move, walk, go”) is from Sanskrit *cal-* (“to move, stir”) — the root of *calan* (“circulation”) and *cañcal* (“restless”). Like Bengali *āshi* and Marathi *yeto*, Hindi leaves by saying “I’m *moving*,” never a blunt “I’m leaving.”

Grammar Lens

The verb agrees with the speaker’s gender. A man says चलता हूँ (*caltā hūṁ*); a woman says चलती हूँ (*caltī hūṁ*). The *-tā* / *-tī* ending marks the speaker — a feature English lacks (compare Marathi *yeto* m. / *yete* f.).

4.6 The farewells

Hindi		Register
अलविदा	<i>alvidā</i>	formal, final (Perso-Arabic)
फिर मिलेंगे	<i>phir milenge</i>	everyday, “we’ll meet again”
कल मिलते हैं	<i>kal milte haiṁ</i>	“see you tomorrow”
चलता हूँ	<i>caltā/caltī hūṁ</i>	casual, “I’ll be off”

Roots banked: *milenge* (*mil-* “to join”), *kal* (*kāla* “time,” cousin of Punjabi *akāl*), *caltā* (*cal-* “to move,” the *-tā*/*-tī* marking the speaker’s gender). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *maiṁ hindī boltā hūṁ* — and Hindi’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ। (*maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ* — “I speak Hindi.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C05-.md.*

5.1 बोलना (*bolnā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ब (*ba*) + ो (the *o*-mātrā) → बो (*bo*); ल (*la*); ना (*nā*). Read बो·ल·ना → *bolnā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बोलना (*bolnā*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (Prakrit *bolla-*, “to utter”). Its ending -ना (*-nā*) is the point: **every** Hindi infinitive ends in *-nā* — *bol-nā* “to speak,” *cal-nā* “to move,” *mil-nā* “to meet.” Strip the *-nā* and you have the **stem** (*bol-*) that takes every other ending.

Grammar Lens

Stem + ending. The stem *bol-* holds the action; endings pin down who and when: *bol-tā* (speaking, m.), *bol-tī* (f.), *bol-o* (speak!, familiar). Every tense is built by adding to a stem like this.

5.2 मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ (*maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ*) — “I speak Hindi”

मैं (I) + हिंदी (Hindi, the object) + बोलता (speak, m.) + हूँ (am) = literally “I Hindi speaking am” — verb-frame last, as always.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The name हिंदी (*hindī*) is a traveller: from *sindhu* (the river Indus) → Persian *hind* (the land beyond it) → *hindī* (“of Hind”). The same *sindhu* gave Greek *Indos* → English **India**, **Indus**, **Hindu**. The language is named, at two removes, after a river.

Grammar Lens

The present habitual = stem + *-tā/-tī* + “to be.”

	Hindi	
a man	मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ	<i>boltā hūṃ</i>
a woman	मैं हिंदी बोलती हूँ	<i>boltī hūṃ</i>
you (resp.)	आप हिंदी बोलते हैं	<i>bolte haiṃ</i>

The *-tā/-tī/-te* agrees in gender and number; *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ* agrees in person. Two agreements, one small sentence.

5.3 रहना (*rahnā*) — “to live, to stay”

The letters in this word

र (*ra*) + ह (*ha*) + ना (*nā*) → रहना. The familiar infinitive -ना.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

रहना (*rahnā*, “to live, remain, stay”), from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain”), covers both “reside” and “keep on”: *maiṃ Dillī meṃ rahtā hūṃ* (“I live in Delhi”), *thīk rahnā* (“stay well”).

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. मैं दिल्ली में रहता हूँ — the word मैं (*meṃ*, “in”) sits *after* Delhi. Hindi uses **postpositions** where English uses prepositions: “Delhi-in I live,” verb last.

5.4 करना (*karnā*) — “to do,” the most useful verb in Hindi

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + र (*ra*) + ना (*nā*) → करना.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करना (*karnā*, “to do, make”) is from the Sanskrit root *kr* (“to do, make”), PIE **k^wer-* — one of the most productive roots in Sanskrit. Its family is already all around you: *karma* (“a thing *done*”), *namaskār* (“the *making* of a bow,” Chapter 1), and the name *Sanskrit* itself (*saṃskṛta*, “put together, perfected”).

Grammar Lens

करना makes verbs out of anything. Noun + *karnā*: *kām karnā* (“work-do” = to work), *bāt karnā* (“talk-do” = to converse), *intizār karnā* (“to wait”). So *maiṃ kām kartā hūṃ* = “I work.”

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Hindi	English
मैं हिंदी बोलता/बोलती हूँ।	I speak Hindi.
मैं दिल्ली में रहता/रहती हूँ।	I live in Delhi.
मैं काम करता/करती हूँ।	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, the *-tā/-tī/-te* that agrees in gender/number, and the *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ* that agrees in person — the verb always last, “in” always after its noun. Roots banked: *bolnā* (Prakrit *bolla-*), *rahnā* (*rah-* “remain”), *karnā* (*kr* — the root of *karma*, *namaskār*, *Sanskrit*), and *hindī* (*sindhu*, the Indus). From here, Hindi’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

6.1 एक, दो, तीन, चार, पाँच — the five forms

Five words, and a story about how languages age.

You'll want to know — The five

	Hindi	said
1	एक	<i>ek</i>
2	दो	<i>do</i>
3	तीन	<i>tīn</i>
4	चार	<i>chār</i>
5	पाँच	<i>pāñch</i>

If you did the writing track you'll recognise some pieces: क (Lesson 2), त (Lesson 2), न (Lesson 1), र (Lesson 4), and the ाI mātrā (Lesson 3).

Plenty here you haven't been taught to draw yet — ए, च, द, प, the ी and ो mātrās, and the ँ. Read them now; you'll draw them when the writing track reaches them.

The ँ over *pāñch* is a *chandrabindu*, “moon-dot” — it nasalises the vowel, the way French does in *bon*.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñch”
- *Point to*: the familiar क, त, न, र and ाI inside the five words
- *Trace it*: the ँ moon-dot over *pāñch*

Before you move on

Count to five in Hindi. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñich.*) Which mark nasalises the vowel in पाँच? (The **chandrabindu**, “moon-dot.”) Do you need to draw every unfamiliar letter today? (**No** — read them now and draw them when their stroke lessons arrive.) Next: watch the Sanskrit forms wear smooth.

6.2 तीन and चार — weight moves from consonants to vowels

The five modern forms did not jump straight from Sanskrit. The Prakrits did most of the wearing-down in between.

You’ll want to know — Put the stages side by side

Sanskrit	→ Prakrit →	Hindi
<i>éka-</i>	<i>ekka</i>	ek
<i>dvá-</i>	<i>do</i>	do
neuter <i>trīṇi</i>	<i>tiṇṇi</i>	tīn
neuter <i>catvāri</i>	<i>cattāri</i>	chār
<i>pāñca</i>	<i>pañca</i>	pāñich

Three and four come from the **neuter** forms. Sanskrit also had masculine *tráyaḥ*, but Hindi *tīn* continues *trīṇi*. The same choice gives *catvāri* → *chār*.

You’ll want to know — The two-step weight trade

1. *trīṇi* → *tiṇṇi*: *r* is lost and **n** doubles to make up the weight. Long *ī* shortens because the doubled consonant already makes the syllable heavy.
2. *tiṇṇi* → *tīn*: the double simplifies and the **vowel lengthens** to pay for the lost consonant weight.

The vowel ends long again after being short in the middle. *Ekka* → *ek* shows the second half of the same trade.

This is not decay in a bad sense; it is what heavy use does over two thousand years. The same ancient number wore down on another continent:

	ancient	modern
Latin → Spanish	<i>quattuor</i>	<i>cuatro</i>
Sanskrit → Hindi	<i>catvāri</i>	<i>chār</i>

Same PIE word, two continents, two ordinary histories.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “trīṇi ... tīṇi ... tīn”
- *Say it*: “catvāri ... cattāri ... **chār**”
- *Compare*: “quattuor → cuatro · catvāri → chār”

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit forms underlie *tīn* and *chār*? (**Neuter** *trīṇi* and *catvāri*.) What sits between Sanskrit and Hindi? (The **Prakrits**.) In *trīṇi* → *tīṇi* → *tīn*, what trades places? (The lost *r* is paid for by a **double consonant**, then the simplified double by a **long vowel**.) Next: follow the nasal that stayed inside *pāmīch*.

6.3 पॉच — the nasal moved into the vowel

Tīn moved weight between consonants and vowels. *Pāmīch* moves a whole nasal sound into the vowel itself.

You’ll want to know — The nasal that stayed

Sanskrit *pañca* → Hindi *pāmīch*. The **n** did not vanish; Sanskrit’s *ñ* consonant became Hindi’s nasalised *ā*. The ॐ chandrabindu records that nasality above the word.

Say *pāmīch* and *pañca* one after the other. You can hear the nasal migrating backward from its own consonant into the vowel.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “pañca ... pāmīch”
- *Hum*: hold the nasal through the vowel in *pāmīch*
- *Point to*: ॐ, the moon-dot that records it

Before you move on

Did the nasal in *pañca* disappear? (**No** — it moved into the vowel.)
What records it in पाँच? (The **chandrabindu**.) Count one to five
once more. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñch.*)

Chapter 7

Yes and No

7.1 हँ (hām) — yes

A single open vowel, said through the nose — that’s Hindi’s yes.

You’ll want to know — The word

हँ = **yes**, said **hām**. It’s the letter ह (h) with the ा sign for long *ā*, and — the key mark — the ँ on top: the **chandrabindu**, the “moon-dot.” It does one thing: it **nasalises** the vowel. So *hām* isn’t “hah” but a humming *hāā̃*, the sound sent up through the nose, the way French does in *bon*.

(Don’t confuse the moon-dot ँ with the plain dot ं *anusvara* you’ll see in the next word — both nasalise, but the moon-dot rides a vowel that has nothing above it, like ाI.)

You’ll want to know — Saying it politely

A bare *hām* is a normal, friendly yes. To an elder, a stranger, or anyone you’d show respect, Hindi adds the honorific जी (*jī*):

जी हँ — *jī hām* — “yes” (polite)

jī on its own is already a respectful “yes.” You met *-jī* on names; here it warms up a plain yes into a courteous one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hām” — let the *ā* hum through your nose

- polite — “jī hām”
- spot the mark — the moon-dot ँ is what nasalises it

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Hindi? (**hām**, हँ.) What does the **chandra-bindu** ँ do to the vowel? (**Nasalises** it — sends it through the nose.) How do you make *hām* polite? (Add जी — *jī hām*.) Next: नहीं, no.

7.2 नहीं (nahīm) — no / not

Hindi’s “no” carries a sound so old it also sits inside German and Latin.

You’ll want to know — The word

नहीं = **no**, said **nahīm** — न (na) + ह (h) + ी (long ī) + the ँ *anusvara* that nasalises the end. The heart of it is that first syllable **na**, which is Hindi’s ancient negator, straight from **Sanskrit na**.

You’ll want to know — The oldest “no” you’ll meet

That **na** is not just Sanskrit’s — it is the same negative root that runs across nearly every language in this course, all descended from one ancient sound, **PIE *ne:**

from ***ne**

Sanskrit <i>na</i>	→ Hindi nahīm
Latin <i>nōn</i>	→ Spanish no , French non
Germanic	→ German nein , English no / not

You met this exact idea in the German *nein* lesson (“not one”); here it is again at the other end of the family, in Hindi. The word for *no* is one of the most stubbornly unchanged things human languages have.

You’ll want to know — One word, two jobs

Like Spanish *no*, **nahīm** is both the **answer** and the **sentence-negator**:

- **answer**: आप आ रहे हैं? — नहीं. (“Are you coming?” — “No.”)

- **negator**: मैं नहीं जानता — “I do **not** know.”

So this single word gives you both “no” and how to make a sentence negative.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nahīm” — nasal at the end, from the *anusvara*
- the ancient root — “na... nōn... nein... no”: one PIE *ne*
- as a negator — “maĩ nahīm jāntā”, “I don’t know”

Before you move on

How do you say no in Hindi? (**nahīm**, नहीं.) What Sanskrit word is its core, and what ancient sound is that from? (**na**, from **PIE *ne**.) Which other course words share that root? (Latin *nōn*, German *nein*, English *no/not* — and Spanish/French *no/non*.) Besides “no,” what else does *nahīm* do? (It **negates a sentence** — *maĩ nahīm jāntā*, “I don’t know.”)

Chapter 8

Please

8.1 कृपया (kṛpayā) — please (kindly)

Hindi’s dictionary word for “please” is really the word **compassion** in disguise — and it’s more formal than you might expect.

You’ll want to know — The word

कृपया = **please**, literally “**kindly / graciously**.” It’s built on the Sanskrit noun कृपा (*kṛpā*), “**grace, compassion, mercy**” — so asking with *kṛpayā* means, at heart, “of your compassion.”

That places Hindi in good company: **Arabic** asks *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”), and the Dravidian languages ask with *daya* (“**compassion**”). A whole swathe of Asia says *please* by naming the kindness it hopes for — a different instinct from French’s “if it **pleases** you.”

The first letter hides a sound you met in the syllabary track: कृ is *ka* carrying the **vocalic r** (the ृ mark) — *kṛ*, the same *r* vowel Sanskrit and the Dravidian scripts share.

You’ll want to know — Be honest about how it’s used

Here’s the catch a textbook often hides: कृपया is **formal and bookish**. You’ll see it on signs and hear it in announcements (“*kṛpayā* mind the gap”), but in everyday speech Hindi speakers rarely say it. Real politeness usually rides on **the verb** instead — the respectful request ending -इए / -इएगा (*-iye / -iyegā*): *baiṭhiye* “please sit,” *sunīye* “please listen.” And very often, people simply say the English word “**please**.”

So learn *kṛpayā* to **read** it and to be formally polite — but know that the living “please” of Hindi is baked into the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kṛpayā” — kṛ with the vocalic r, then -payā
- the root — “kṛpā = compassion” → “of your compassion”
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “baiṭhiye” = “please sit”

Before you move on

What is the formal Hindi word for please? (कृपया *kṛpayā*.) What does its root *kṛpā* mean, and which other languages ask the same way? (“**Grace / compassion**” — like Arabic *min faḍlik* and Dravidian *daya*.) Is *kṛpayā* what people usually say out loud? (**No** — it’s formal; everyday politeness rides on the verb ending *-iye/-iyegā*, or people say English “please.”)

Chapter 9

Sorry

9.1 माफ़ कीजिए (māf kījiye) — please forgive me / sorry

You already know the formal कृपया (*kṛpayā*), “please.” Hindi’s everyday “sorry” is built the same way you build a request: **name the kindness, ask for it to be done.**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- माफ़ (*māf*) = “**forgiven, pardoned**” — not a native Hindi word at all! It’s borrowed through **Persian** from **Arabic** عفو (*‘afw*), “to pardon, efface, wipe away [a wrong].” Look closely at the spelling: the dot under फ़ (called a **nuqtā**) turns the plain *pha* sound into **fa** — Hindi’s way of writing sounds that arrived from Persian and Arabic.
- कीजिए (*kījiye*) = the **respectful imperative** “**please do**,” from करना (*karnā*), “to do.”

So माफ़ कीजिए is literally “**please do forgiven[-ness]**” — *please make [this] forgiven*. It’s the same light-verb move you’ve already met: naming a state (forgiveness, kindness, compassion) and asking someone to *do* it.

You’ll want to know — Be honest about register — and about English creeping in

माफ़ कीजिए is warm and genuinely everyday — but Hindi keeps a **more formal, Sanskritic** cousin for writing and ceremony: क्षमा करें (*kṣamā karēmi*),

“please grant **kṣamā**” — from Sanskrit क्षमा (*kṣamā*), “patience, forbearance, forgiveness.” Where *kṛpayā* was the bookish “please,” **kṣamā karēṇī** is the bookish “sorry.”

And here’s the honest twist: in casual conversation, many Hindi speakers simply say the **English word “sorry”** outright — it has been fully adopted into everyday Hindi, the same way English “please” sometimes stands in for *kṛpayā*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “māf” — forgiven — then “kījiye,” please do
- the whole phrase — “māf kījiye” = please forgive me
- the formal cousin — “kṣamā karēṇī”

Before you move on

What does माफ़ कीजिए literally mean? (“**Please do forgiven[-ness]**” — *māf* “forgiven” + *kījiye* “please do.”) Where does *māf* come from? (**Borrowed via Persian from Arabic** *ʿafw*, “to pardon.”) What’s the more formal, Sanskritic cousin? (क्षमा करें *kṣamā karēṇī*, from *kṣamā* “patience/forgiveness.”) What do many Hindi speakers just say instead, casually? (**The English word “sorry.”**)

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

10.1 सोमवार to शुक्रवार — Hindi’s own planet-week

You’ve seen Spanish, Latin, and French name their weekdays for planet-gods. Here’s the surprise: **Hindi does too** — with its own, independent set of gods.

You’ll want to know — The pattern: [deity] + वार, “day”

Every Hindi weekday is a **deity’s name** plus वार (*vār*), “**day**” (Sanskrit *vāra*):

Hindi	literally	deity/planet	day
सोमवार (<i>somavār</i>)	Soma’s day	the Moon	Monday
मंगलवार (<i>maṅgalvār</i>)	Mangala’s day	Mars	Tuesday
बुधवार (<i>budhvār</i>)	Budha’s day	Mercury	Wednesday
गुरुवार (<i>guruvār</i>)	Guru’s day	Jupiter (<i>Bṛhaspati</i> , called “Guru,” teacher of the gods)	Thursday
शुक्रवार (<i>śukravār</i>)	Śukra’s day	Venus	Friday

You’ll want to know — Be honest about where this system came from

This is **the same seven-body idea** as Rome’s planetary week — Sun, Moon, Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn — and it is **not** an isolated Indian invention: historians trace it, ultimately, to a shared source in **Babylonian astronomy**, and most accounts hold that it reached both Rome and India through the **same Hellenistic-Greek channel** of transmission (India’s own horoscopic-astrology texts, like the *Yavanajātaka*, are explicitly adapted from Greek originals). The exact path and timing into India are still debated among historians of astronomy, but the system isn’t a case of Rome and India copying each other directly — both are more like **cousins**, downstream of one much older shared idea of the sky.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “somavār” — Soma/Moon’s day — then “maṅgalvār,” Mangala/Mars’s day
- the pattern — “[deity] + vār” = [deity]’s day
- “guruvār” — Thursday — Br̥haspati, called “Guru”

Before you move on

What does every Hindi weekday end in, and what does it mean? (वार *vār*, “day.”) Which planet is गुरुवार, and what title does its deity carry? (**Jupiter** — the deity Br̥haspati, called “**Guru**,” teacher of the gods — an ancient title Br̥haspati bears, not the source of the word itself.) Did Hindi borrow its planet-week from Rome? (**No** — both likely trace back through **Hellenistic Greece** to a shared **Babylonian** astronomical source, though the exact route into India is still debated.)

10.2 शनिवार and रविवार — Saturday and Sunday, no rewrite needed

You’ve met five Hindi weekdays, each a deity’s name plus वार (*vār*), “day.” The last two complete the set — and here, unlike

Spanish or French, **nothing ever got renamed**.

You'll want to know — The last two days

- शनिवार (*śanivār*) = “**Śani’s day**” — **Saturn**.
- रविवार (*ravivār*) = “**Ravi’s day**” — the **Sun** (*Ravi*, one of the Sun’s many Sanskrit names).

You'll want to know — Be honest about the contrast with Spanish and French

Remember: Spanish’s **sábado/domingo** and French’s **samedi/dimanche** are **not** simple planet-names — Christianity renamed both (Saturn’s day became the *Sabbath*; the Sun’s day became “*the Lord’s day*”). Hindi’s weekend went through **no such rewrite**: शनिवार and रविवार are still, today, plainly “Saturn’s day” and “Sun’s day” — the full planet-week, all seven days, standing untouched by any later religious relabeling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śanivār” — Saturn’s day — then “ravivār,” Sun’s day
- the whole week — “somavār, maṅgalvār, budhvār, guruvār, śukravār, śanivār, ravivār”
- the contrast — Spanish/French renamed their weekend; Hindi never did

Before you move on

What do शनिवार and रविवार literally mean? (“**Saturn’s day**” and “**Sun’s day**.”) How is Hindi’s weekend different from Spanish’s or French’s? (**No religious rewrite ever happened** — Hindi kept the plain planet-names for all seven days, while Spanish/French swapped in *Sabbath* / *Lord’s day* for the weekend.)

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

11.1 काला, सफ़ेद (kālā, safed) — black and white

Hindi’s word for black hides something bigger inside it: the very same word Sanskrit uses for **time itself** — and for death.

You’ll want to know — काला — black, time, and death, tangled together

काला (*kālā*) = “**black**,” from Sanskrit काल (*kāla*), a word that covers both “**black/dark**” and “**time**.” Sanskrit’s own tradition ties the two together poetically — **time devours everything**, and that devouring is imagined as *dark* — and the same word names the fierce goddess **Kālī** (“the black/dark one”) and stands as an epithet of **Yama**, the god of death. Be honest, though: whether “black” and “time” are truly **one and the same root**, or two separate ancient words that Sanskrit poetry and theology later **fused** into a single idea, is a real, still-debated question among linguists — the cultural connection is certain; the precise etymology underneath it is not.

You’ll want to know — सफ़ेद — a Persian loan

सफ़ेद (*safed*) = “**white**” — borrowed from **Persian** (سفید *safēd*), the same kind of Persian-into-Hindi borrowing you’ve already met in माफ़ (*māf*, “for-given,” from the “sorry” lesson). Notice the नुक्ता (*nuqtā*, the dot under फ़): it turns *pha* into **fa**, the tell-tale mark of a sound that arrived from Persian or Arabic.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kāla” — time/black/death, then “kāla” — black
- “safed” — white, a Persian loan
- the dot — नुक्ता under फ turns pha into fa

Before you move on

What does काला’s root काल (*kāla*) also mean, besides “black”? (“**Time**” — and by extension, **death**; the same word names the goddess **Kālī** and Yama’s epithet **Kāla**.) Is it settled that “black” and “time” are the same root? (**No** — the cultural link is real and ancient, but linguists still debate whether it’s one true root or two words later fused.) Where does सफ़ेद come from? (**Persian** *safēd* — the same kind of loan as *māf*, “sorry.”)

11.2 लाल, नीला (*lāl*, *nīlā*) — a gemstone’s name, and India’s dye

One more color pair, and one more Persian loan — plus a Sanskrit word connected to why English itself says “**indigo**.”

You’ll want to know — लाल — named for a gem, not a color

लाल (*lāl*) = “**red**” — borrowed from Persian لعل (properly *la^l*, with a middle ^{ayn} the Hindi/Persian pronunciation *lāl* smooths over), which originally named a specific **deep-red gemstone** (a ruby or spinel), and only later widened to mean the color itself. Hindi’s everyday word for “red” started life as a jeweler’s word.

You’ll want to know — नीला — Sanskrit’s dark blue, and the world’s word for indigo

नीला (*nīlā*) = “**blue**,” from Sanskrit नील (*nīla*), “dark blue” — also the name of the **indigo plant** and its dye. Here’s the honest, careful version of a famous connection: English “**indigo**” does **not** come from *nīla* by sound change. It comes from **Greek** *indikón*, simply meaning “**the Indian [thing]**” — because Greek and Roman traders imported the blue dye **from India**. So *nīlā* and “indigo” aren’t the same word evolving — they’re two **separate** words for the same dye, one Indian (*nīla*, describing the color)

and one foreign (*indikón*, describing the dye’s *origin*). The connection is real, but it’s a connection of **history and trade**, not of sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lāl” — red, originally a gemstone’s name
- “nīlā” — blue, from Sanskrit *nīla*
- the honest distinction — *nīla* and “indigo” are two different words linked by trade, not by sound

Before you move on

What did लाल originally name, before it meant “red”? (**A deep red gemstone**, borrowed from Persian.) Does English “**indigo**” come directly from Sanskrit नील *nīla*? (**No** — indigo is from Greek *indikón*, “the Indian [thing],” describing where the dye came from; *nīla* and “indigo” are two separate words connected by history, not by sound change.)

Chapter 12

Family

12.1 पिता, माता (pitā, mātā) — father and mother, cousins across a huge family

You’ve already met Latin **pater/māter** and their English cousins **father/mother** — all descending from one ancient shared word. Hindi keeps a cousin of its own, in the very same family.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- पिता (*pitā*) = “**father**” — Sanskrit पितृ (*pitṛ*), from the **same PIE root, *ph₂tēr***, as Latin *pater* and English *father*.
- माता (*mātā*) = “**mother**” — Sanskrit मातृ (*mātr*), from ***méh₂tēr***, the same root as Latin *māter* and English *mother*.

So *pitā* and *father* are, at the deepest level, the **same ancient word** — reaching you here through Sanskrit rather than through Latin or Germanic, one more branch of the same very old family tree.

You’ll want to know — Be honest about register — the everyday words

पिता/माता are correct, respectable Hindi — but the words you’ll hear **most often in daily life** are different: बाप (*bāp*, “father,” an everyday/colloquial word) and माँ (*māñi*, “mother,” universally the warm, everyday word — closer to English “mom” than “mother”). These aren’t uncertain outliers, either — they’re **also** Sanskrit-descended, just by a different path than

pitā/mātā: बाप traces through Prakrit to Sanskrit वपृ (vapṛ, “father,” a different Sanskrit root from *pitṛ*), while माँ is a genuine **doublet** of *mātā* — both come from the very same Sanskrit *māṭṛ*, just worn down along a more colloquial Prakrit line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pitā, mātā” — the Sanskrit-descended, formal pair
- “bāp, māṁ” — the everyday, spoken pair
- the deep cousin — “pitā and father are the same ancient PIE word”

Before you move on

What are पिता and माता cousins of, in Latin and English? (**Pater/father** and **māter/mother** — all from the same PIE roots.) What are the everyday, spoken words instead? (बाप **bāp** and माँ **māṁ**.) Are *bāp* and *māṁ* also Sanskrit-descended? (**Yes** — *bāp* traces to Sanskrit *vapṛ*, a different root from *pitṛ*; *māṁ* is a genuine **doublet** of *mātā*, both from *māṭṛ*.)

12.2 भाई, बहन (bhāī, bahin) — one cousin word, one different word entirely

You’ve met *frāter* and *soror* as PIE cousins of “brother” and “sister.” Hindi’s pair has a genuine surprise hiding in it: only **one** of these two continues that ancient family.

You’ll want to know — भाई — the expected cousin

भाई (*bhāī*) = “**brother**” — from Sanskrit भ्रातृ (*bhrāṭṛ*), which **does** continue the same PIE root, *b^hréh₂tēr*, as Latin *frāter* and English *brother*. This one is exactly what you’d expect: one more cousin in the same old family.

You'll want to know — बहन — NOT the expected cousin

Sanskrit did have a direct PIE-cognate word for “sister” too: स्वसृ (*svasr*), the very cousin of Latin *soror* and English *sister*. But that word **faded from use**. In its place, Sanskrit built a **different** word, भगिनी (*bhaginī*) — and *that* word, not *svasr*, is the confirmed ancestor of Hindi’s everyday बहन (*bahin*). (Where *bhaginī* itself comes from is the less certain part: it’s often explained as भग (*bhaga*, “a share, good fortune”) plus a feminine suffix, “the one who shares” — but Sanskritists don’t all agree on this, and some suspect it’s a reshaping of an older form avoiding an unrelated, indelicate sense of *bhaga*. That deeper question is worth a linguist’s extra check; the *bahin* ≠ *svasr* finding itself is solid.)

So Hindi’s brother/sister pair is **lopsided** in its ancestry: *bhāī* genuinely continues the ancient PIE word; *bahin* comes from an entirely different Sanskrit formation that **replaced** the PIE-cognate word before Hindi ever inherited it. (Sanskrit-to-Hindi sound history has plenty of non-obvious turns.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhāī” — brother — the true PIE cousin of “brother”
- “bahin” — sister — from *bhaginī*, “the one who shares,” NOT from the PIE word for sister
- the asymmetry — one cousin, one completely different word

Before you move on

Does भाई continue the same ancient root as English “brother”? (**Yes** — Sanskrit *bhrātṛ* < PIE *b^hréh₂tēr*, same as Latin *frāter*.) Does बहन continue the same ancient root as English “sister”? (**No** — Sanskrit’s PIE-cognate word, *svasr*, faded; *bahin* comes from भगिनी *bhaginī*, an unrelated Sanskrit formation — often glossed “the one who shares,” though *bhaginī*’s own deeper origin is itself debated.)

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

13.1 सिर (sir) — the head

A short, everyday word — and, once you look, a worn-down piece of a much older Sanskrit word you may recognize from yoga or anatomy.

You'll want to know — The word

सिर (*sir*) = “**head**” — from Sanskrit शिरस् (*śiras*), “head.” Centuries of everyday use wore the word down from the fuller, formal Sanskrit shape to the short, simple *sir* you use every day.

Sanskrit’s *śiras* root is still alive in more formal/technical registers too — related *śīrṣa*-based vocabulary shows up in yoga and Ayurvedic anatomical terms (as in poses and positions named for the head), even while everyday Hindi kept the shorter, worn-down *sir*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sir” — head
- the fuller Sanskrit source — “śiras”
- worn down over time — “śiras → sir”

Before you move on

What does सिर mean, and what Sanskrit word is it worn down from? (“**Head**” — from शिरस् *śiras*.) Where else does this root show up, in a more formal register? (**Yoga/anatomical terms** built on the related *śr̥ṣa* root.)

13.2 हाथ (hāth) — the hand

This word looks nothing like its Sanskrit ancestor at first glance — but the change between them follows a real, traceable pattern, not a random drift.

You’ll want to know — The word

हाथ (*hāth*) = “**hand**” — from Sanskrit हस्त (*hasta*), “hand.”

You’ll want to know — The honest sound-change story

Getting from *hasta* to *hāth* isn’t one clean step — it passed through **Prakrit** (the everyday spoken languages that stood between Sanskrit and modern Hindi) along the way: Sanskrit’s **-st-** consonant cluster regularly simplified in Prakrit into a **geminate** (doubled), **aspirated** consonant (giving an intermediate form like *hattha*). Later, as that doubled consonant simplified further down to modern Hindi’s single **-th-**, the **vowel just before it lengthened** — *a* becoming *ā* — as if to make up for the sound that was lost. That’s the general shape of the change: **- st- → (Prakrit geminate aspirate) → single aspirate + a longer vowel** — a recognized pattern in how Sanskrit consonant clusters evolved into modern Hindi, not a one-off coincidence for this word alone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hāth” — hand
- the Sanskrit source — “hasta”
- the shape of the change — “-st- cluster → simplified consonant + longer vowel”

Before you move on

What does हाथ mean, and what Sanskrit word is it from? (“**Hand**” — from हस्त *hasta*.) What’s the general shape of the sound change between them? (**Sanskrit’s -st- cluster simplified** through Prakrit into a **geminate** aspirated consonant (*hattha*), which later simplified to a single consonant — and the vowel before it **lengthened** to compensate.)

Chapter 14

Seasons

14.1 वसंत, ग्रीष्म, वर्षा, शरद्, हेमंत, शिशिर — six seasons, not four

Every European language in this course splits the year into **four** seasons. Hindi’s own tradition doesn’t — it recognizes **six**, and this isn’t extra vocabulary bolted onto a four-season frame. It’s a genuinely different way of dividing the year.

You’ll want to know — The six ऋतु (ṛtu, “seasons”)

Hindi	rough Western match
वसंत (<i>vasant</i>)	spring
ग्रीष्म (<i>grīṣma</i>)	summer
वर्षा (<i>varṣā</i>)	monsoon/rains — no Western equivalent
शरद् (<i>śarad</i>)	autumn
हेमंत (<i>hemant</i>)	pre-winter/late autumn
शिशिर (<i>śiśir</i>)	deep winter

This six-season calendar, ऋतु (*ṛtu*), is rooted in classical Sanskrit tradition and Indian astronomy/astrology, and it maps onto the actual climate of much of the Indian subcontinent far better than a four-season frame does: the **monsoon** (*varṣā*) is a real, distinct, and hugely important season there — not a subdivision of “summer” or “autumn,” but its own season with no clean Western counterpart. And the cold season splits into **two** stages, *hemant* (the onset) and *śiśir* (deep winter), rather than being lumped into one “winter.”

You'll want to know — Be honest: don't force the four-season frame onto this

It would be a mistake to just match these six words one-to-one against Spanish's four or French's four the way earlier lessons matched *tala* to *talai*. The **structure itself is different** — six real seasons, not four plus two extras. Everyday spoken Hindi *does* also use looser, more casual four-part talk about seasons (borrowing straightforwardly from the idea of “summer,” “winter,” etc.), but the traditional, classical ऋतु system is genuinely six-fold, and it's worth learning as its own thing rather than squeezed into someone else's frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six — “vasant, grīṣma, varṣā, śarad, hemant, śiśir”
- the one with no Western match — “varṣā,” the monsoon
- the honest point — six seasons is a different STRUCTURE, not extra vocabulary

Before you move on

How many seasons does Hindi's traditional ऋतु calendar recognize? (**Six**, not four.) Which season has no clean Western equivalent, and why? (वर्षा *varṣā*, the **monsoon** — a real, distinct season central to the subcontinent's climate.) Is this just extra vocabulary added to a four-season frame? (**No** — it's a genuinely different structural division of the year.)

Chapter 15

Water and Bread

15.1 पानी, रोटी (pānī, roṭī) — water (the “drinkable thing”) and bread

Hindi’s everyday word for water isn’t the ancient Sanskrit word you might expect — it names water by what you **do** with it, not by what it **is**.

You’ll want to know — पानी — “the drinkable thing”

पानी (*pānī*) = “**water**.” Sanskrit actually has older, more “basic” words for water — आप् (*āp*) and जल (*jala*) among them — but Hindi’s everyday word descends from neither. It comes from Sanskrit पानीय (*pānīya*), built on the verb पा (*pā*), “**to drink**,” plus a suffix meaning roughly “**fit for**.” So *pānīya*, and Hindi’s *pānī* after it, literally means “**the drinkable thing**” — water defined by its use, not named as a substance in its own right.

You’ll want to know — रोटी — bread, honestly uncertain in origin

रोटी (*roṭī*) = “**bread, flatbread**” — the everyday word for the flatbreads (roti, chapati-style breads) central to North Indian meals. Be honest: unlike *pānī*, *roṭī*’s deeper history is **not cleanly traced** back through Sanskrit the way many everyday Hindi words are. It comes through Prakrit रोट्ट (*roṭṭa*, “a kind of bread”) from Sanskrit रोटिका (*roṭikā*); beyond that, one proposal (Turner’s Indo-Aryan dictionary) tentatively links it to a root meaning “**to strike / to press or crush**” — perhaps evoking the pounding and flattening of dough — but this is genuinely uncertain, one guess among scholars

rather than a settled chain. Worth knowing honestly rather than forcing a confident derivation that isn't there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pānī” — water, “the drinkable thing”
- the root — “pā,” to drink, + “-nīya,” fit for
- “roṭī” — bread, flatbread

Before you move on

Does पानी come from Sanskrit's ancient water-words, *āp* or *jala*? (**No** — from पानीय *pānīya*, “the drinkable thing,” from पा *pā*, “to drink.”) Is रोटी's etymology as clearly traced as *pānī*'s? (**No** — it traces to Prakrit *roṭṭa* < Sanskrit *roṭikā*, but beyond that the deeper root is genuinely uncertain — one proposal links it to “striking/pressing” dough, not a settled chain.)

Chapter 16

Months

16.1 जनवरी to दिसंबर — borrowed names, and a second calendar underneath

Like Arabic, Hindi doesn't have just **one** set of months — everyday civil life and traditional/religious life run on **two different calendars**.

You'll want to know — The Gregorian months — recent, borrowed

For dates, school, business, and government, Hindi uses month names borrowed straightforwardly from **English**:

जनवरी, फरवरी, मार्च, अप्रैल, मई, जून, जुलाई, अगस्त, सितंबर, अक्टूबर, नवंबर, दिसंबर (*janvarī, farvarī, mārc, aprail, maī, jūn, jūlāī, agast, sitambar, ak-tūbar, navambar, disambar*) — you can hear “January,” “March,” “August” right through the Hindi pronunciation. This is a modern civil borrowing, not an ancient Sanskrit system.

You'll want to know — Be honest: the traditional calendar is a genuinely different structure

Hindu tradition keeps its **own**, much older lunisolar calendar — विक्रम संवत् (*Vikram Samvat*) — with twelve **different** month names: चैत्र, वैशाख, ज्येष्ठ, आषाढ़, श्रावण, भाद्रपद, आश्विन, कार्तिक, मार्गशीर्ष, पौष, माघ, फाल्गुन (*Chaitra, Vaiśākh, Jyēṣṭha, Āṣāḍh, Śrāvaṇ, Bhādrapad, Āśvin, Kārtik, Mārgaśīrṣ, Pauṣ, Māgh, Phālgun*).

This isn't just a second set of labels for the same twelve solar months — these months are tied to the **six-ṛtu** seasonal calendar from the sea-

sons lesson (in the traditional/classical scheme, each pair of Vikram Samvat months corresponds to one of the six *ṛtu*), and major festivals (Holi, Diwali, and many others) are dated by **this** calendar, not the Gregorian one — which is why their Gregorian-calendar date shifts from year to year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “janvarī, mārc, agast” — hear the borrowed English names
- the traditional calendar — “Chaitra, Vaiśākh, Jyeṣṭha”
- the honest point — festivals shift on the Gregorian calendar because they’re dated by Vikram Samvat instead

Before you move on

Where do Hindi’s everyday civil month names come from? (**Borrowed from English** — *janvarī, mārc, agast...*) What traditional calendar runs alongside it, and what is it tied to? (**Vikram Samvat** — tied to the **six ṛtu** seasons, not the four-season Western frame.) Why do festivals like Holi and Diwali fall on different Gregorian dates each year? (**They’re dated by Vikram Samvat**, a different calendar system entirely.)

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

17.1 दोपहर, आधी रात — noon by an old clock, midnight fully transparent

Hindi’s word for noon hides a whole traditional timekeeping system inside it — one very different from hours and minutes.

You’ll want to know — दोपहर — “two pahars”

दोपहर (*dopahar*) = “**noon, midday**” — literally “**two** (*do*) + **pahar**.” A पहर (*pahar*, from Sanskrit *prahara*) is a traditional Indian unit of time, roughly **three hours** long, with the day traditionally divided into eight *pahars* (four for daytime, four for night), counted from sunrise. Noon falls right around the end of the **second** daytime *pahar* after sunrise — so *do-pahar*, “two pahars [in],” became the everyday word for midday. (This traditional *pahar*-based account is the standard one, though — as with any folk-timekeeping etymology this old — treat the exact number of *pahars* as the general shape of the story rather than a precisely dated fact.)

You’ll want to know — आधी रात — fully transparent “half night”

आधी रात (*ādhī rāt*) = “**midnight**,” literally “**half night**” — आधी (*ādhī*, the feminine form of आधा, *ādhā*, “half”) + रात (*rāt*, “night”). No erosion, no double meaning — structurally identical to Latin’s *media nox* and Spanish’s *medianoche*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pahar” — a traditional ~3-hour watch — then “do-pahar,” two pahars, noon
- “ādhī rāt” — half night, midnight
- the contrast — dopahar counts an old time-unit; ādhī rāt is plainly “half” + “night”

Before you move on

What does दोपहर literally mean, and what’s a *pahar*? (“**Two pahars**” — a *pahar* being a traditional ~3-hour time-unit, with noon falling around the end of the second one after sunrise.) What does आधी रात literally mean? (“**Half night**” — *ādhī* “half” + *rāt* “night,” fully transparent, just like Latin’s *media nox*.)

Chapter 18

Telling Time

18.1 घंटा — “hour,” literally “bell”

Here’s a word that wears its history on its sleeve: Hindi’s word for “hour” is the exact same word as “bell.”

You’ll want to know — घंटा — bell AND hour, one word

घंटा (*ghaṇṭā*) = “**hour**” — and it means “**bell, gong**” just as commonly. It comes from Sanskrit घण्टा (*ghaṇṭā*), “bell, gong.” The connection isn’t a coincidence: temples, towns, and later clock towers historically marked the passing of time by **striking a bell** — the hour was announced by sound, not read off a face — so the word for the bell itself came to mean the unit of time it announced. Compare this to English **o’clock**, itself a worn-down “**of the clock**,” or French’s **il est ... heures**: different languages, but time-telling vocabulary keeps circling back to the *instrument* used to mark it.

Grammar Lens: बजना — “to strike, to toll”

Hindi tells the time with the verb बजना (*bajnā*), “**to strike, to toll**” — the same imagery as a bell striking the hour:

एक बज रहा है। — “It is one o’clock.” (literally “**one is striking**”) दो बज रहे हैं। — “It is two o’clock.” (literally “**two are striking**”)

Just like Spanish switches from singular *es* to plural *son* after “one,” Hindi switches बज रहा है (singular) to बज रहे हैं (plural) once the count passes one — matching the number, not just tacking on “o’clock.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ghaṇṭā” — hour, also “bell”
- “ek baj raha hai” — it is one o’clock, “one is striking”
- “do baj rahe hain” — it is two o’clock, “two are striking”

Before you move on

What does घंटा literally mean besides “hour”? (“**Bell, gong**” — from Sanskrit *ghaṇṭā*.) Why did “bell” come to mean “hour”? (Because clocks/towns historically **struck a bell** to announce the hour.) What verb does Hindi use to tell the time, and what does it literally mean? (बजना, *bajnā* — “to strike, to toll,” as in *ek baj raha hai*, “one is striking.”)

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

19.1 उम्र — the same word as Arabic

You just met Arabic's *ʿumr*. Hindi's everyday word for “age” is the **exact same word**, carried through Persian.

You'll want to know — उम्र — a Perso-Arabic loan, and a native alternative

उम्र (*umr*) = “age” — this is **Arabic's** *ʿumr*, borrowed into Hindi through Persian, and it's the everyday, colloquial word most Hindi speakers use. Hindi also has a fully **native Sanskrit** alternative, आयु (*āyu*, “age, lifespan”), which feels more formal or literary — a register split you've now seen several times (compare Kannada's Sanskrit-tatsama *madhyāhna* vs. Tamil's native words for the same concepts, just flipped here: the **borrowed** word is the everyday one, the **native** word is the formal one).

Your turn

- *Say it*: “umr” — age, same word as Arabic's *ʿumr*
- *Contrast*: everyday *umr* · formal/literary *āyu*

Before you move on

What language does Hindi's उम्र come from, and what's the native Sanskrit alternative? (**Arabic** *ʿumr*, via Persian; native alternative is आयु, *āyu*.) Which one is ordinary conversational Hindi? (**Umr**.) Next: use a genitive marker to say how many years someone belongs to.

19.2 कितने साल के हो? — belonging to so many years

Languages do not agree on whether age is something you have, are, were born with, or state without a verb. Hindi gives the idea a fifth shape.

You'll want to know — The two sentences

तुम कितने साल के हो? — “How old are you?” (informal), literally “you, of how many years, are?” (*tum kitne sāl ke ho?*)

मैं बीस साल का हूँ। — “I am twenty years old,” literally “I [am one] belonging to twenty years.” (*main̄ bīs sāl kā hūñ.*)

के/का (*ke/kā*) is Hindi's **genitive postposition**, “of, belonging to.” The same marker family handles possession elsewhere: *merā ghar*, “my house.”

So Hindi does not copy Romance's “I **have** years,” Germanic's simple “I **am** [a number],” Latin's “**born** + N years,” or Arabic's verbless “my age [is] N.” It says “I am [one] **belonging to** N years,” with a genitive marker plus होना (*honā*, “to be”).

Your turn

- *Say it:* “tum kitne sāl ke ho?” — how old are you?
- *Say it:* “main̄ bīs sāl kā hūñ” — I belong to twenty years
- *Point to:* **ke/kā** — the genitive, “of/belonging to”

Before you move on

What does के/का mark? (A **genitive/possessive** relationship.) Does Hindi use Romance “have,” simple Germanic “be,” Latin “born,” or Arabic's verbless sentence? (**None:** it says “belonging to N years” + *honā*.)

Chapter 20

Weather

20.1 मौसम — another Perso-Arabic loan, and a false-friend trap

You’ve already seen Hindi borrow *umr* from Arabic. Here’s another one — and this time, English borrowed the SAME root too.

You’ll want to know — मौसम — the same root as “monsoon”

मौसम (*mausam*) = “weather” — borrowed from Classical Persian موسم (*mawsim*), itself from Arabic مَوْسِم (*mawsim*, “season, time of year, occasion”; likely originally used by Arab sailors for seasonal winds). This is the **exact same root** that gave English **monsoon** — carried into English in the **1580s**, well before the British Raj, via **Portuguese and Dutch** traders in the Indian Ocean spice trade (Portuguese *monção*, Dutch *monssoen*, both from this same Arabic *mawsim*). So “monsoon” and Hindi’s everyday word for “weather” are, quite directly, the same word.

You’ll want to know — गर्मी है, ठंड है — heat and cold, native words

गर्मी है। — “It’s hot.” — literally “**there is heat.**” (*garmī hai.*)
ठंड है। — “It’s cold.” — literally “**there is cold.**” (*ṭhaṇḍ hai.*)

Both use ordinary Hindi nouns (गर्मी, “heat”; ठंड, “cold”) plus है (*hai*, “is/there is”) — simpler in shape than Arabic’s fully verbless pattern, since Hindi still needs *hai* here.

You’ll want to know — बारिश vs. वर्षा — a genuine false-friend trap

Hindi has **two** words for “rain” that sound similar enough to assume they’re related — **don’t** make that assumption:

- बारिश (*baarish*) — from **Persian** بارش (*bāriš*) — the everyday, colloquial word: बारिश हो रही है (“it’s raining,” literally “rain is happening”).
- वर्षा (*varṣā*) — fully **native Sanskrit**, from वर्ष (*varṣá*, “rain”), tracing to **Proto-Indo-European** *h₁wers-* (“to rain”) — cousin of Greek *hḗrsē* (“dew”) and Old Irish *frass* (“rain-shower”). This is the more formal/literary word.

Despite the similar sound, dictionaries flag *baarish* and *varṣā* as **probably not related** — one’s a Persian loan, the other a native Sanskrit inheritance from deep in the Indo-European family. A likely false-friend trap, not a confirmed doublet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mausam” — weather, same root as English “monsoon”
- “garmī hai. thandī hai.” — it’s hot / it’s cold
- “baarish hai” (everyday) vs. “varṣā” (formal) — probably NOT related despite sounding alike

Before you move on

What English word shares मौसम’s exact root, and how did it reach English? (**Monsoon** — from Arabic *mawsim* via Persian, carried into English in the 1580s by Portuguese/Dutch traders, well before the British Raj.) Are बारिश and वर्षा related words? (**Probably not** — despite sounding similar, *baarish* is a Persian loan and *varṣā* is native Sanskrit; dictionaries flag them as likely unrelated.) What PIE root does वर्षा trace to, and what’s its Greek cousin? (*h₁wers-*, “to rain” — cousin of Greek *hḗrsē*, “dew.”)

Chapter 21

Numbers Six to Ten

21.1 छह, सात, आठ, नौ, दस — six to ten, the same erosion twice more

You already watched *tr̥ṇi* wear down to *t̥n* in two careful steps.
Two more numbers here do exactly the same thing.

You'll want to know — The five

	Hindi	said
6	छह	<i>chhah</i>
7	सात	<i>sāt</i>
8	आठ	<i>āṭh</i>
9	नौ	<i>nau</i>
10	दस	<i>das</i>

You'll want to know — *sapta* → *satta* → *sāt*, *aṣṭa* → *aṭṭha* → *āṭh* — the same mechanism again

Put seven and eight beside their Sanskrit ancestors:

Sanskrit	→ Prakrit →	Hindi
<i>saptá</i>	<i>satta</i>	<i>sāt</i>
<i>aṣṭá</i>	<i>aṭṭha</i>	<i>āṭh</i>

This is the **identical two-step process** you already watched turn *tr̥ṇi* into *t̥n*:

1. The consonant cluster (*-pt-*, *-ṣṭ-*) **simplifies into a doubled consonant** (*-tt-*, *-ṭṭh-*) — the same weight, packed into one place.
2. The doubled

consonant **simplifies again**, and the **vowel lengthens** to pay for what was lost — *satta* → *sāt*, *aṭṭha* → *āṭh*.

Same trade, same reason, two more numbers. This is exactly what the anchor lesson meant by “not decay in any bad sense” — it’s the standard Prakrit weight-conservation move, and by now you’ve seen it three times.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “chhah, sāt, āṭh, nau, das”
- the repeated mechanism — “saptá ... satta ... **sāt**” and “aṣṭá ... aṭṭha ... **āṭh**”

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Hindi. (*Chhah, sāt, āṭh, nau, das*.) What mechanism do *sāt* and *āṭh* share with lesson 6’s *tīn*? (**Cluster simplifies to a geminate, then the geminate simplifies again and the vowel lengthens** — the same weight-conservation move, three numbers running.) Next: compare the three different histories inside six, nine, and ten.

21.2 छह, नौ, दस — three different paths

Seven and eight repeated a familiar weight trade. Six, nine, and ten show that not every number took the same road.

You’ll want to know — ṣaṣ → chhah — a sibilant moves forward

छह (*chhah*) continues Sanskrit **ṣaṣ**, “six.” The retroflex sibilant ṣ shifted forward into Hindi छ (*ch*). This is separate from cluster simplification, but it is still two thousand years of ordinary speech reshaping a Sanskrit word.

You’ll want to know — nava → nau — a consonant dissolves

नौ (*nau*) continues Sanskrit **nava**. The **v** between vowels weakened and disappeared; the vowels on either side contracted into the diphthong *-ava-* → *-au-*. Compare *pāmich*: there a nasal moved into the vowel; here an intervocalic consonant dissolved between two vowels.

You'll want to know — *daśa* → *das* — the quiet path

दस (*das*) continues Sanskrit **daśa** most plainly: the final vowel drops. There is no cluster to simplify and no middle consonant to lose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ṣaṣ ... chhah” — the sibilant shifts
- “nava ... nau” — *v* dissolves into a diphthong
- “daśa ... das” — only the final vowel drops

Before you move on

What happened to **v** in *nava* → *nau*? (It **dissolved between vowels**, which contracted.) Which form changed least? (**Das** — only the final vowel dropped.) Count six to ten once more. (*Chhah*, *sāt*, *āṭh*, *nau*, *das*.)

Chapter 22

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

22.1 ग्यारह, बीस — genuinely irregular, and one honest exception

Be honest about this one: Hindi's teens don't follow a clean, predictable pattern the way Spanish's or Latin's do. But hiding inside that irregularity is a real echo of something you just saw in Latin.

The two words — Eleven to twenty

	Hindi	said
11	ग्यारह	<i>gyārah</i>
12	बारह	<i>bārah</i>
13	तेरह	<i>terah</i>
14	चौदह	<i>chaudah</i>
15	पंद्रह	<i>pandrah</i>
16	सोलह	<i>solah</i>
17	सत्रह	<i>satrah</i>
18	अठारह	<i>aṭhārah</i>
19	उन्नीस	<i>unnīs</i>
20	बीस	<i>bīs</i>

The two words — Honest irregularity

Unlike Spanish's transparent *dieciséis-diecinueve* or even the fused-but-regular *once-quince*, Hindi's 11-18 each descend from their own Sanskrit

number-word (*ekādaśa*, *dvādaśa*, *trayodaśa*...) through centuries of individually unpredictable erosion. Most end in **-rah**, a worn-down echo of Sanskrit’s “-daśa” (“ten”), but the erosion of each number’s front half isn’t predictable from the number itself — these genuinely have to be memorized one by one, the way English speakers just memorize “eleven” and “twelve” rather than deriving them.

The two words — उन्नीस

Here’s the honest exception: उन्नीस (*unnīs*, 19) most likely isn’t simply a worn-down “nine-ten” — it likely continues Sanskrit’s **own** special, **subtractive** name for 19: ऊनविंशति (*ūnaviṃśati*), literally “**one less than twenty**” (from *ūna*, “less, deficient,” + *viṃśati*, “twenty” — a later, shortened form of the fuller Vedic *ekonaviṃśati*, “one-less-twenty,” with the *eka*, “one,” eventually dropped). Sanskrit used this same *ūna*-/ *ekona*- (“one-less-than”) subtractive pattern for every number ending in 9 up through 99 — 29, 49, 99, all named as “one less than” the next round number.

This is a genuine, striking parallel to something you already met: **Latin’s own ūndēvīgintī** (“one from twenty”) for 19, from the numbers-11-20 lesson. Two completely unrelated language families — Indo-Aryan and Italic, both descended from Proto-Indo-European but separated for thousands of years — independently landed on the exact same subtractive logic for naming nineteen.

The two words — बीस

बीस (*bīs*, “twenty”) continues Sanskrit विंशति (*viṃśati*, “twenty”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gyārah, bārah, terah” — 11, 12, 13, each individually memorized
- “unnīs” — 19, most likely “one less than twenty” (*ūnaviṃśati*), echoing Latin’s *ūdēvīgintī*
- “bīs” — twenty

Before you move on

Do Hindi's numbers 11-18 follow a predictable pattern the way Spanish's teens do? (**No** — each is individually eroded from its own Sanskrit ancestor and must be memorized.) What does उन्नीस most likely preserve from Sanskrit, and what does it mean? (Sanskrit's **subtractive** *ūnaviṃśati*, “**one less than twenty**.”) What Latin number from an earlier lesson uses the exact same subtractive logic? (**ūndēvigintī**, “one from twenty” — two unrelated language families, the same idea.)

Chapter 23

Dog and Cat

23.1 कुत्ता — a third mystery dog-word

You have met a mystery dog-word in Spanish and another in English/German. Hindi genuinely gives you a **third**.

You'll want to know — कुत्ता — a third mystery, displacing Sanskrit's own PIE word

Sanskrit's actual, **inherited** word for dog was श्वान (*śvān*) — the **exact same PIE root**, **kwon-*, behind Latin's *canis*, English's *hound*, and German's *Hund*. It's the **only** word for dog found in the R̥gveda. But everyday Hindi doesn't use *śvān* at all — the ordinary word is कुत्ता (*kuttā*), which traces through Prakrit to a Sanskrit form, कुरकुर (*kurkura*). Its ultimate origin is honestly **unresolved** — serious proposals split between an **onomatopoeic** origin (imitating a dog's bark) and a **non-Indo-Aryan substrate** word borrowed from an unrelated language family, with no consensus on which is right. Either way, *kuttā* quietly pushed *śvān* into rare, formal, literary use — the **exact same shape of story** as Spanish's *perro* displacing *can*, and English's *dog* displacing *hound*. Three unrelated language families, three mystery words, all crowding out the same inherited PIE word for “dog.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kuttā” — dog, genuinely uncertain origin, displacing Sanskrit's own *śvān*
- “śvān” — the PIE-inherited word, now rare and formal

Before you move on

What was Sanskrit’s actual inherited word for “dog,” and what family does it belong to? (श्वान, *śvān* — same PIE root as Latin *canis*, English *hound*, German *Hund*.) Does everyday Hindi use *śvān*? (**No** — *kuttā* displaced it, echoing Spanish’s *perro* and English’s *dog*.) Is *kuttā*’s own origin settled? (**No** — genuinely disputed between an onomatopoeic origin and a non-Indo-Aryan substrate word.) Next: follow Hindi’s cat-word into a probable fourth family.

23.2 बिल्ली — a probable fourth cat-word family

Hindi’s dog-word joined three mysteries. Its cat-word probably opens a family separate from the widespread *qitt/cattus/gato/chat/Katze* story.

You’ll want to know — The route into Hindi

बिल्ली (*billī*, “cat”) traces through Sauraseni Prakrit to Sanskrit बिडालिका (*biḍālikā*), a diminutive of बिडाल (*biḍāla*, “cat”).

Be honest about the deeper step: most linguists consider *biḍāla* a loan-word **into Sanskrit from Dravidian**, but this is not universal. Some scholars are skeptical of the comparison; another serious proposal derives it from an unattested native compound, ***vidāla***, “that which tears apart small birds.”

If the leading Dravidian account is right, *billī* belongs to a probable fourth cat-word family. Arabic *qitt*, Latin *cattus*, Spanish *gato*, French *chat*, and German *Katze* are usually linked to one Afro-Asiatic source; Hindi’s word would instead descend from a word Sanskrit borrowed from Dravidian.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “billī” — cat
- *Trace it*: *biḍāla* → *biḍālikā* → Prakrit → *billī*
- *Qualify*: “probably Dravidian, not proven”

Before you move on

Where does बिल्ली most likely come from? (**Dravidian**, via Sanskrit *biḍāla*.) Is that universally agreed? (**No** — it is the leading account with serious alternatives.) Why is this a new cat-word family? (It is probably separate from the *qitt/cattus* family.)

Chapter 24

Green and Yellow

24.1 हरा — a color cousin hiding in plain sight

Hindi's green word shares deep roots with words other languages use for yellow.

You'll want to know — हरा — a hidden cousin of jaune and gelb

हरा (*harā*, “green”) comes from **Sanskrit** हरित (*harita*, “green, yellowish, tawny”) — a well-documented descendant of **Proto-Indo-European** **ǵʰelh₃-*, “to shine.” That confirmed root is also behind **German**’s *gelb* (via Proto-Germanic **gelwaz*) and English’s own “yellow” and “gold” — making Hindi’s word for **GREEN** a genuine cousin of German’s word for **YELLOW**. **French**’s *jaune* is usually traced to this same family too, via Latin *galbinus* — though, honestly, that particular link is **less secure** than the others: some modern Latin scholarship treats *galbus*’s origin as unknown rather than confirming the **ǵʰelh₃-* connection. So here’s the honest surprise: Hindi’s word for **GREEN** and German’s word for **YELLOW** are, at the deepest level, **cousins** — not a contradiction, since this root originally covered a blurry “shining, yellow-to-green” zone before languages carved out different pieces of it. Sanskrit *harita* itself kept some of that blur, historically covering shades from green through yellowish and tawny, before Hindi’s *harā* settled specifically on “green.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “हरा” — green, a hidden PIE cousin of German’s *gelb*

- “*g^helh₃-* — shine, then a yellow-to-green color zone”

Before you move on

What ancient Proto-Indo-European root connects **harā** to German’s *gelb*? (**g^helh₃-*, “to shine” — Hindi’s GREEN word is a genuine cousin of German’s YELLOW word; French’s *jaune* is usually placed in this family too, though that link is less secure.) Why can one root yield green and yellow words? (It once covered a broader **shining yellow-to-green zone**.) Next: the yellow word whose sound history is clear but meaning history is not.

24.2 पीला — clear sounds, uncertain meaning

Harā gave a secure ancient color family. Hindi’s yellow word gives a secure sound chain wrapped around an unsolved semantic mystery.

You’ll want to know — The chain

पीला (*pīlā*, “yellow”) traces through Prakrit पीअल (*pīāla*) to Sanskrit पीतल (*pītala*), built on पीत (*pīta*).

Pīta means “yellow,” but also literally “**drunk, quaffed**,” from a root meaning “to drink.” Why do “yellow” and “drunk” share a word? The connection is **not settled**. One proposed path runs “drink” → “become full or swell” → “the color of fat” → “yellow,” but sources flag that mechanism as uncertain.

What is solid is the ordinary sound history:

pīta → *pītala* → *pīāla* → *pīlā*

Keep the evidence levels separate: trust the forms; label the semantic bridge a hypothesis.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “*pīlā*” — yellow
- *Trace it*: “*pīta* · *pītala* · *pīāla* · *pīlā*”
- *Qualify*: “drink → yellow is uncertain”

Before you move on

What does **pīta** also mean? (**Drunk, quaffed.**) Is the bridge from drinking to yellow settled? (**No.**) What part is secure? (The sound chain $pīta \rightarrow pītala \rightarrow pīāla \rightarrow pīlā$.)

Chapter 25

Day

25.1 दिन (din) — “day,” the same root as diēs, a different branch

You’ve already met this word once, tucked inside *dopahar* (“noon,” literally “two pahars” of the **day**). Now it stands alone — and its connection to Latin’s *diēs* is real, but more careful than it first looks.

You’ll want to know — दिन — “day”

दिन (din) — “day” — is the ordinary Hindi word for “day,” already implicit in दोपहर (*dopahar*, “noon,” Chapter 17).

You’ll want to know — The same ultimate root as diēs — but a separate branch

Din traces to **Sanskrit** दिन (*dina*), from **Proto-Indo-Iranian** **dinám* — a **suffixed** formation built on **Proto-Indo-European** **dyew-* (“to shine, sky”), the same ultimate root behind **Latin**’s own **diēs**. But be careful: *din* and *diēs* aren’t the closest possible cousins — they took **separate derivational paths** off that shared root. *Din*’s own closest relatives are actually the Baltic/Slavic “day”-words, **Lithuanian** *diena* and **Proto-Slavic** **dьnь*. The genuinely **direct**, unsuffixed cousins of *diēs* are Sanskrit’s own द्यु (*dyu*, “heaven, sky”) and दिव् (*div*, “sky”) — which give दिवस (*divasa*), yet another everyday Hindi word for “day.” So the honest picture: *din* and *diēs* share one distant ancestor, but *dyu/div* are the tighter match.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “din” — “day,” already met inside dopahar
- the shared root — din and Latin’s diēs, same PIE root *dyew-*, “to shine,” but different derivational branches
- the closer cousins — dyu, div, “heaven/sky” — the tighter, unsuffixed match for diēs

Before you move on

Where have you already met दिन before this lesson? (दोपहर, *dopahar*, “noon.”) What ancient PIE root connects Hindi’s **din** to Latin’s **diēs**, and what does it mean? (**dyew-*, “to shine, sky” — but through **separate branches**, not as the closest cousins.) Which Sanskrit words are actually the **tighter, more direct** cousins of *diēs*? (द्यु *dyu* and दिव् *div*.)

Chapter 26

Night

26.1 रात (raat) — “night,” and an honest false cousin of Latin’s nox

Last lesson, *din* turned out to be a real (if distant) cousin of Latin’s *diēs*. This lesson is the mirror image: *raat* looks like it should be *nox*’s cousin too — but it genuinely isn’t.

You’ll want to know — रात — “night”

रात (**raat**) — “**night**” — is the word already hiding inside आधी रात (*ādhī rāt*, “midnight,” Chapter 17). It comes down through a completely ordinary sound-change chain: **Sanskrit** रात्रि (*rātri*) → **Prakrit** रत्ति (*ratti*, consonant cluster simplifying) → Hindi रात (*raat*) — the same shape of erosion you’ve already seen in Hindi’s numbers (*saptá* → *sāt*, *aṣṭá* → *āṭh*).

You’ll want to know — A genuine false cousin — not a true cognate

Here’s the honest twist: रात्रि (*rātri*) traces to **Proto-Indo-Iranian** **HráHtriH*, from **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-trih₂* — built from a root meaning “**to rest, remain still**,” plus a feminine suffix. This is a **completely different** PIE root from Latin’s **nox** (from **nók^wts*, the root behind English “night” itself, German *Nacht*, Greek *nyx*). Both *rātri* and *nox* are genuine Indo-European “night” words, in related language branches — but they are **not** cousins. Unlike *din* and *diēs* last lesson, which really do share one ancestor, *raat* and *nox* just happen to both mean “night,” from two entirely separate ancient roots. Sanskrit actually **does** keep a true *nók^wts* cousin of its own — नक्तम् (*naktam*, “by night”) — but it’s an

archaic, adverbial word; it's *rātri*, not *nakṭam*, that won the job of everyday Hindi's *raat*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*raat*” — “night,” already met inside *ādhī rāt*
- the sound chain — *rātri* → *ratti* → *raat*, the same erosion pattern as *saptá* → *sāt*
- the honest twist — *raat* and *nox* are NOT cousins, unlike *din* and *diēs*

Before you move on

Where have you already met रात before this lesson? (आधी रात, *ādhī rāt*, “midnight.”) What Sanskrit word, and what sound-change chain, gives Hindi **raat**? (रात्रि *rātri* → Prakrit *ratti* → *raat*.) Are *raat* and Latin's *nox* true cognates, the way *din* and *diēs* are? (**No** — genuinely different PIE roots, **h₁reh₁-* “to rest” vs. **nók^wts* — a false cousin, despite both meaning “night.”)

Chapter 27

Good Night

27.1 शुभ रात्रि (śubh rātri) — “good night,” the formal doublet in action

Hindi keeps two versions of “night” side by side — one for everyday speech, one for set phrases. Here’s where the formal one gets used.

You’ll want to know — शुभ रात्रि — “auspicious night”

शुभ रात्रि (śubh rātri) — “good night” — literally “auspicious night.” Notice: this uses रात्रि (rātri), the very Sanskrit word last lesson’s *raat* descended **from** — but here, kept in its **full, unworn Sanskrit** form. This is a classic **tatsama/tadbhava doublet**: *rātri* (tatsama, a direct, unchanged Sanskrit borrowing) sits alongside *raat* (tadbhava, the same word worn down by centuries of ordinary sound change) — Hindi keeps both, one for everyday speech, one for set formal phrases like this one.

You’ll want to know — शुभ — “auspicious,” from a root meaning “to shine”

शुभ (śubh) — “auspicious, good, fortunate” — comes from the Sanskrit verbal root शुभ् (śubh), whose core sense is “to be beautiful, splendid.” This traces to a well-sourced **Proto-Indo-European** root, **kewb^h-* (“to be beautiful”). Some scholars propose a **further, more speculative** connection beyond that — to **(s)kewh₁-* (“to perceive”) or **kew-* (“to shine”) — but that deeper link, not the **kewb^h-* root itself, is the genuinely uncertain part. Either way, the underlying idea is a familiar one: **auspiciousness imagined as a kind of radiance or beauty** — something good “shines.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubh rātri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- the formal doublet — rātri here, raat in everyday speech
- śubh’s own root — śubh, “to shine” → “auspicious”

Before you move on

Does शुभ रात्रि use the everyday *raat* or the formal *rātri*? (**The formal *rātri*** — Hindi keeps both versions, one for everyday speech, one for set phrases.) What does शुभ literally trace back to? (A root meaning “**to be beautiful, splendid,**” PIE **kewb^h*- — auspiciousness as a kind of radiance.) Is that root itself uncertain, or is a *further* proposed connection the shakier part? (**The root **kewb^h*- itself is well-sourced** — it’s the *deeper* proposed link, to “to shine” or “to perceive,” that’s genuinely speculative.)

Chapter 28

Morning

28.1 सुबह (subah) — “morning,” and a root you’ve already met, in Arabic

दिन and रात were both Sanskrit words, straight through. This one breaks that pattern completely — and lands somewhere you’ve genuinely been before, in a different language entirely.

You’ll want to know — सुबह — a real surprise: not Sanskrit at all

सुबह (subah) — “morning” — is Hindi’s everyday, ordinary word for morning. Unlike दिन (*din*) and रात (*raat*, both Sanskrit tatsama, met the last two lessons), *subah* is genuinely **borrowed**: from **Persian** صبح (*subh*), itself from **Arabic** صبح (*ṣubḥ*), built on the Arabic triliteral root ح-ب-ص (*ḥ-b-ṣ*, “dawn, to become morning”).

You’ll want to know — A root you’ve technically already learned — in Arabic

Here’s the honest callback: this is the **exact same** Arabic root already met in this course’s Arabic arc — inside خير على تصبح (*tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*, “good night,” literally “may **you wake into goodness**,” built on this very root, AR-C27). Hindi’s everyday word for “morning” and Arabic’s own good-night farewell — a phrase that never even mentions “night” — both trace to the **same three Arabic consonants**, ح-ب-ص, arriving in Hindi by a completely different route (via Persian) than they did staying in Arabic.

You'll want to know — Be honest: *din* and *raat* didn't prepare you for this

Don't assume every Hindi time-word will be Sanskrit just because *din* and *raat* were. *Subah* is a genuine break in the pattern — a reminder that “everyday Hindi word” and “Sanskrit tatsama” aren't the same category, even when the last two examples made it look that way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “subah” — “morning,” genuinely a Persian/Arabic loan
- the shared root — ṣ-b-ḥ, the same three consonants inside Arabic's *tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*
- the honest break — unlike *din* and *raat*, *subah* is NOT Sanskrit

Before you move on

Is सुबह a Sanskrit tatsama, like दिन and रात? (**No** — a genuine Persian/Arabic loanword.) What Arabic phrase, already taught in this course, shares सुबह's exact root? (خير على تصبح, *tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*, “good night” — both trace to the Arabic root ح-ب-ص, ṣ-b-ḥ.)

Chapter 29

Evening

29.1 शाम (shaam) — “evening,” and a tempting false cognate

Last lesson’s सुबह was Persian, not Sanskrit. This word is the same story — but this time there’s a Sanskrit look-alike close enough to trip you up on purpose.

You’ll want to know — शाम — Persian again, not Sanskrit

शाम (shaam) — “evening” — is, like *subah*, a genuine **Persian** loan-word: from Persian شام (*šām*), which traces back through **Proto-Iranian** **xšáfnyah* to **Proto-Indo-Iranian** **kšápā* (“night”). Hindi’s two everyday time-words for “morning” and “evening” both entered the language **via Persian**, not Sanskrit — though their deeper roots differ: *subah*’s traces further back to **Arabic**, while *shaam*’s is native **Indo-Iranian**, a sister branch to Sanskrit itself. Persian is what they share directly; their ultimate origins are not the same.

You’ll want to know — Be careful: a tempting, but FALSE, cognate

Here’s the trap: Sanskrit has its own word, श्यामा (*śyāmā*, “dark, night-colored”), that *looks* like it should be *shaam*’s cousin — similar sound, overlapping “darkness/night” meaning, right in the neighborhood you’d expect. It **isn’t**. *Shaam* and *śyāmā* trace to **two completely separate roots** that simply converged on similar sounds and meanings by coincidence — a genuine **false cognate**, not a shared one. Don’t let the resemblance fool you into inventing a connection that isn’t there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shaam” — “evening,” another genuine Persian loan
- the tempting trap — Sanskrit śyāmā looks related but ISN’T
- subah and shaam — both Persian, Hindi’s whole “morning and evening” pair borrowed from the same source language

Before you move on

Is शाम Sanskrit or Persian? (**Persian** — from शाम, śām, like subah.) Is शाम related to Sanskrit श्यामा (śyāmā, “dark”)? (**No** — a genuine false cognate; the resemblance is coincidental, not a shared root.) What do subah and shaam have in common, beyond both meaning a time of day? (**Both are Persian loanwords** — Hindi’s morning/evening pair, unlike din/raat, isn’t Sanskrit at all.)

Chapter 30

Afternoon

30.1 दोपहर — the same word, a wider job than its etymology promised

You already know दोपहर means “noon” — two pahars after sunrise, precisely. This lesson’s honest twist is that the word doesn’t stay that precise in everyday use.

You’ll want to know — दोपहर — same word, a broader modern meaning

दोपहर (**dopahar**) is the exact word you met in Chapter 17, still literally “**two pahars**” (traditional ~3-hour watches, counted from sunrise) — but in **modern, everyday Hindi**, it no longer points only at that precise midday instant. Say दोपहर में (*dopahar mein*, “in the dopahar”) to arrange a meeting, and you’re pointing at a stretch of time — roughly **noon through late afternoon** — not a single moment. The historical etymology gave the word a very specific target (the end of the second daytime *pahar*); everyday usage has since widened that target into the general block of time most languages call “the afternoon.”

You’ll want to know — Be honest: etymology and modern meaning have drifted apart

This is worth sitting with: दोपहर’s **literal** story still holds up the way Chapter 17 described it — “two pahars,” with noon falling around the end of the second — though, as that lesson itself noted, treat the exact pahar-count as the general shape of the story rather than a precisely dated fact. Either

way, the **word's job** in the language has moved on well past that etymology. This kind of drift — a word for one precise instant loosening into a name for a whole surrounding stretch of time — isn't unique to Hindi, but here it's especially visible because Chapter 17 showed you exactly how tight the original math was.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dopahar” — the same word from Chapter 17, “two pahars”
- “dopahar mein” — “in the afternoon,” a modern, widened usage
- the honest twist — the etymology stayed precise; the word's actual job widened past it

Before you move on

Is दोपहर a new word, or the same one from Chapter 17? (**The same word** — “two pahars.”) Does modern Hindi use दोपहर to mean only the exact instant of noon? (**No** — it's widened to cover the whole afternoon, roughly noon through late afternoon.) Has दोपहर's etymology itself changed to match this wider modern use? (**No** — the etymology still points precisely at noon; only the word's everyday job has widened.)

Chapter 31

Good Morning

31.1 सुप्रभात (suprabhāt) — “good morning,” a different root than the noun

सुबह was Persian, borrowed whole. This lesson’s “good morning” isn’t built on it at all — it reaches for entirely different, native vocabulary.

The two words — सुप्रभात

सुप्रभात (suprabhāt) — “good morning” — is built from सु (*su*, “good”) plus प्रभात (*prabhāta*, “dawn, daybreak”) — and *prabhāta* is **native Sanskrit**, from प्रभा (*prabhā*, “light, splendour”), itself from the root भा (“to shine”) plus the preverb प्र- (“forth”), plus the suffix -त (-*ta*). This is a **completely different word** from सुबह (*subah*, HI-C28), the Persian/Arabic loan you use for the everyday noun “morning.” Hindi’s “morning” and “good morning” don’t share a root at all.

The exchange — Formal register

Here’s a genuine, checked-not-assumed finding — hedged carefully, since this arc’s earlier lesson (Telugu’s TE-C25) only ever offered a similarly hedged claim itself: some sources describe Telugu speakers often code-switching to English “good night” instead of their own Sanskrit-descended phrase, though even that lesson admitted the evidence was thin and might apply more broadly across South Asian languages, not just Telugu. सुप्रभात’s own story is different again, and just as worth hedging: it skews toward **formal, written** contexts — speeches, radio, the well-known Hindi WhatsApp-forward “good morning image” culture — rather than casual spoken conversation,

where नमस्ते commonly covers mornings too. That’s a real formal/everyday split, but it isn’t the same thing as being displaced by **English** specifically — there’s no strong evidence for that particular substitution here. Don’t assume every “good _____” greeting in every language this course covers follows the same displacement story; verify each one on its own, and don’t flatten a hedge into a fact either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “suprabhāt” — “good morning,” su + prabhāt
- the root contrast — subah is Persian, prabhāt is native Sanskrit — completely different words
- the honest note — suprabhāt skews formal/written; नमस्ते covers casual mornings; no strong evidence of English displacement

Before you move on

Does सुप्रभात share a root with सुबह? (**No** — सुबह is Persian/Arabic; प्रभात, inside suprabhāt, is native Sanskrit, ultimately from भा, “to shine.”) Is सुप्रभात commonly used in casual spoken Hindi? (**Not especially** — it skews formal/written, with नमस्ते commonly covering mornings in everyday speech.) Is it being displaced by English “good morning,” the way some sources (thinly) suggested for other languages’ night greetings in this arc? (**No strong evidence of that** — its own story is a formal/everyday split, not an English substitution.)

Chapter 32

Good Evening

32.1 शुभ संध्या (shubh sandhyā) — “good evening,” a twilight word with two lives

शाम was Persian. This greeting reaches for something else again — a native Sanskrit word for the exact moment day and night meet.

You’ll want to know — संध्या — “the junction of day and night”

संध्या (sandhyā) — “evening, twilight” — is **native Sanskrit**, from सम् (sam-, “together”) + धा (dhā, “to hold, to place”), literally “**holding together**” — the **junction** where day and night meet. This is a genuinely different word from शाम (shaam, HI-C29’s Persian loan): Hindi’s everyday evening noun and its “good evening” greeting don’t share a root, the same pattern already found for morning.

You’ll want to know — साँझ — a doublet, but not a simple “casual” version

संध्या has its own Hindi **tadbhava** doublet, साँझ (sāñjh), worn down through Prakrit the same way रात्रि became रात (HI-C26/27). But be careful not to force that exact parallel: unlike *rātri/raat*, where the tadbhava form clearly became the everyday word and the tatsama stayed formal, sources describe साँझ as used across **both** literary/poetic **and** everyday communication — not simply “the casual one.” The doublet exists; the clean formal/casual split doesn’t carry over as neatly this time.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “shubh sandhyā” — “good evening,” su + sandhyā
- *Say it:* sandhyā’s own meaning — “holding together,” the junction of day and night
- *Contrast:* tatsama sandhyā · evolved doublet sāñjh

Before you move on

What does संध्या literally mean, and what is it built from? (“**Holding together**” — सम् + धा — i.e. the junction of day and night.) Does साँझ work the same way रात्रि/रात’s tatsama/tadbhava split did — one strictly formal, one strictly casual? (**No** — साँझ is used across both literary and everyday registers, not confined to one.) Next: choose between the written greeting and the casual all-day greeting.

32.2 शुभ संध्या or नमस्ते? — choose by setting

Shubh sandhyā is structurally transparent. The final question is where Hindi speakers actually reach for it.

You’ll want to know — Written warmth and casual speech

Like सुप्रभात, शुभ संध्या appears heavily in **written and social greeting-card culture**: greeting poetry, WhatsApp messages, and evening well-wishes. It is less likely to open an ordinary mid-conversation exchange.

नमस्ते works at any time of day, evenings included, and is more common in casual conversation than either *shubh prabhāt* or *shubh sandhyā*. The native language has divided the jobs: a Sanskrit “good _____” phrase for formal or written warmth, and another native greeting for everyday speech.

This is not English displacing a Hindi greeting. It is Hindi choosing between two of its own expressions by register and medium.

Your turn

- *Choose:* a WhatsApp evening card → शुभ संध्या
- *Choose:* greeting someone casually at 7 p.m. → नमस्ते
- *Say it:* “formal/written is a tendency, not an absolute ban”

Before you move on

Where does शुभ संध्या especially thrive? (**Written and social greeting-card culture.**) Does नमस्ते genuinely work in the evening? (**Yes** — it works at any time and is common casually.) Is the distinction Hindi versus English? (**No** — it is a native register/medium choice.)

Chapter 33

Good Afternoon

33.1 शुभ दोपहर (shubh dopahar) — “good afternoon,” this arc’s rarest greeting

You already know दोपहर’s meaning widened from “precisely noon” to “the afternoon.” This greeting rides that widened sense — but it’s the least commonly heard of the three you’ve now met.

You’ll want to know — शुभ दोपहर — “good afternoon,” using the widened sense

शुभ दोपहर (shubh dopahar) — “good afternoon” — pairs शुभ (“good”) with दोपहर used in the **widened, modern sense** from last lesson: “the afternoon” generally, not the narrow etymological “exactly noon.” Good news for consistency: this greeting confirms दोपहर’s widened meaning is the one people actually reach for here — nobody uses शुभ दोपहर to mean “good [precise instant of] noon.”

You’ll want to know — Be honest: the rarest of the three, not just another formal phrase

Here’s the twist this lesson adds, verified independently rather than assumed from सुप्रभात or शुभ संध्या’s pattern: of this arc’s three शुभ+timeword greetings, शुभ दोपहर is described as the rarest in actual spoken use — even more so than the other two. Sources call it formal/written, note that casual alternatives like आपका दोपहर शुभ हो (“may your afternoon be good”) exist but are themselves still uncommon, and confirm नमस्ते/नमस्कार do the real everyday greeting work across the whole afternoon, same as for morning and

evening. This isn't just "another formal Sanskrit-style greeting" — it's the weakest-attested of the three, a genuine difference in **degree**, not just the same story repeated a third time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "shubh dopahar" — "good afternoon," using दोपहर's widened modern sense
- the honest ranking — of सुप्रभात, शुभ संध्या, and शुभ दोपहर, this one is the rarest in actual spoken use
- नमस्ते/नमस्कार — the real everyday greeting, covering afternoons too

Before you move on

Does शुभ दोपहर use दोपहर's narrow "noon" sense or its widened "afternoon" sense? (**The widened sense** — "good afternoon," not "good [exact] noon.") Is शुभ दोपहर the most, or least, commonly used of this arc's three शुभ+timeword greetings? (**Least** — described as the rarest of the three in actual spoken use.) What covers the real everyday afternoon greeting instead? (नमस्ते/नमस्कार.)

Chapter 34

Four Verbs of the Mind

34.1 सोचना (sochnā) — “to think,” and it used to mean “to grieve”

You can already run a Hindi verb: strip the -ना, keep the stem, add -ता/-ती/-ते and होना. Here is a verb worth running that machine on, because its history is a small shock.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

सोचना (sochnā) = “to think.” It behaves itself completely: the infinitive ends in -ना like every Hindi verb, and the stem is सोच- (soch-). So मैं सोचता हूँ (mairi sochtā hūmī, m.) / मैं सोचती हूँ (sochti, f.) — “I think.” Respectfully, आप सोचते हैं (āp sochte haimi).

The stem is also a noun on its own. सोच (soch) means “a thought” — and, just as ordinarily, “worry.” Hold on to that double meaning; the word’s history is the reason for it.

You’ll want to know — thinking that started out as grieving

सोचना comes down from Sanskrit शोचति (śocati) — “burns; grieves; mourns” — on the root शुच् (śuc-). Through Prakrit the sound softened and the sense drifted: *burn* → *be consumed by something* → *brood on it* → plain *think*. Hindi’s ordinary word for thinking is an old word for sorrow that cooled down.

Be honest about the limits: शुच् has **no secure English cousin**. Nothing *think*-shaped waits at the other end of this trail, and inventing one would be worse than saying so.

What travels instead is the **shape** of the change. English **think** and **thank** are one Germanic root — to thank someone was to *think well of* them. Latin **pēnsāre** meant “**to weigh**,” which is why English has **pensive**. Three unrelated families, three mind-verbs, not one of them starting out meaning “to think.”

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *maini sochtā hūmī* · (f.): *maini sochtī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: “you (resp.) think” — *āp sochte haimi*
- *Say it*: *nahīmī* on its own, then slide it in front of the verb — *maini nahīmī sochtā / sochtī*, “I don’t think so.” Hindi’s negator sits **before** the verb, never after it
- *Say it*: the noun *soch*, and both things it means — a thought, and a worry

Before you move on

What did *śocati* mean before it meant “think”? (**To burn, to grieve.**) Which everyday Hindi noun still carries both halves, and where does *nahīmī* sit in *maini nahīmī sochtā*? (**सोच**, a thought *and* a worry; *nahīmī* goes **before the verb**.) Is there an English cousin of *śuc-*? (**No.**)

34.2 समझना (samajhnā) — “to understand,” which is to say “to wake up”

Sochnā got you thinking. This verb gets you the single most useful sentence a beginner owns — the one you say when you have **not** understood.

The letters in this word

स (*sa*) + म (*ma*) → सम; then झ (*jha*), the breathy pair of *ja*; then ना (*nā*). Read स · म · झ · ना → *samajhnā*. The झ is one puff of air heavier than a plain *j*, the same aspiration that separates Hindi’s *k* from its *kh*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

समझना (*samajhnā*) = “to understand.” Stem समझ-, so मैं समझता हूँ (m.) / मैं समझती हूँ (f.), and respectfully आप समझते हैं.

Like *soch*, the bare stem is a noun: समझ (*samajh*) is “understanding, sense, judgement.”

And the sentence to bank tonight: मैं नहीं समझता / समझती — “I don’t understand.” Put माफ़ कीजिए in front of it and you have a complete, polite repair: *māf kījiye, maimi nahīni samajhtā* — “Sorry, I don’t understand.” Every word of that you already had.

You’ll want to know — the root that gave the Buddha his name

The standard derivation takes समझना back to Sanskrit सम् (*sam-*, “fully, together”) + the root बुध् (*budh-*, “to wake, to become aware”). Older Hindi still says समुझना (*samujhnā*), and that surviving *-u-* is the fingerprint of *budh-* before it wore down.

So you already know this root in English, twice over, because English took the words whole:

- बुद्ध (*buddha*) — “the one who woke up.” English **Buddha**.
- बोधि (*bodhi*) — the awakening itself; and बुद्धि (*buddhi*), intellect.

Further back, *budh-* rests on the reconstructed root *bheudh-*, and its Germanic branch surfaces in English **bode**, **forebode** and **forbid** (*for-* + “announce”). Hindi’s “I understand,” then, is a claim to have woken up — and the Buddha’s title is the same claim, made once and for all.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *maini samajhtā hūni* · (f.): *maini samajhti hūni*]
- Say it: the repair, slowly — *māf kījiye, maimi nahīni samajhtā / samajhti*
- Say it: *maini sochtā hūni* then *maini samajhtā hūni* — thinking, then getting it
- Say it: *buddha* and *bodhi*, and what *budh-* means underneath them (to wake)

Before you move on

What are the two pieces inside *samajhnā*? (सम् “fully” + बुध् “to wake.”) Say “Sorry, I don’t understand.” (*Māf kījiye, maini nahīni samajhtā / samajhti.*) Which famous title is built on the same root, and what does it mean? (**Buddha** — “the one who woke up.”)

34.3 पढ़ना (*paṛhnā*) — “to read,” and just as often “to study”

One verb, two English words. And one letter you have never had to say out loud before.

The letters in this word

प (*pa*), then ढ, then ना (*nā*) → प · ढ · ना.

That middle letter is ढ (*dha*) wearing the **nuqtā** — the same small dot you met under फ़ in *māf*, Hindi’s mark for a sound the plain letter cannot carry. Dotted, ढ becomes a **flap**: curl the tongue back to the roof of the mouth and let it snap forward, with a breath behind it. That is **ṛh**. The word is *paṛhnā*, not *padhna*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पढ़ना (*paṛhnā*) = “to read” — and, with no change at all, “to study.” Stem पढ़-: मैं पढ़ता हूँ (m.) / मैं पढ़ती हूँ (f.); आप पढ़ते हैं.

Two words grow straight off that stem, and both are everywhere in Indian life: पढ़ाई (*paṛhāī*) = “studies, schooling,” and पढ़ाना (*paṛhānā*) = “to teach” — literally “to cause to read.”

You’ll want to know — reading, when reading meant reciting

The ancestor is Sanskrit पठति (*paṭhati*) — “recites; reads aloud.” Not *scans a page*. Sanskrit’s name for its oldest texts is श्रुति (*śruti*), “that which is heard”: the Veda was memorised and spoken, and to “read” it was to say it. That is why one Hindi verb still covers reading and studying — for centuries they were the same act.

The sound wore down on the ordinary road: *paṭhati* → Prakrit *paḍhai* → *paṛhnā*, the hard **ṭh** loosening between two vowels into the flap you just made.

And the honest note: **paṭh-** has no secure Indo-European ancestry. No English cousin, and possibly not an inherited Indo-Aryan word at all. Where the trail stops, this book stops with it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the flap alone — ṛh, ṛh — then the whole word, paṛhnā
- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi paṛhtā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi paṛhtī hūmī* — and mean both “I read” and “I study”]
- *Say it*: do what the verb originally meant — recite एक, दो, तीन, चार, पाँच, छह, सात, आठ, नौ, दस aloud, one to ten, then say *mairi paṛhtā hūmī*
- *Say it*: *mairi paṛhtā hūmī*, then *mairi samajhtā hūmī* — read it, then get it

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *paṛhnā* cover? (**Read** and **study**.) What did *paṭhati* mean, and why does that explain the pair? (**To recite aloud** — reading was saying.) Recite one to five in Hindi from memory. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñch.*)

34.4 लिखना (likhnā) — “to write,” which everywhere means “to scratch”

Reading has its verb. Here is the other half — and the chapter’s four mind-verbs come back together at the end of it.

The letters in this word

ल (*la*) with the short ि → लि (*li*); then ख (*kha*); then ना (*nā*) → लि · ख · ना.

The ि is the one that runs ahead of itself: it is drawn to the **left** of ल but sounded **after** it, exactly as in हिंदी. Devanagari writes the mark first and your mouth says it second — *li*, never *il*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

लिखना (*likhnā*) = “to write.” Stem लिख-: मैं लिखता हूँ (m.) / मैं लिखती हूँ (f.); आप लिखते हैं.

Its Sanskrit ancestor is लिखति (*likhati*), and *likhati*’s first meaning is not “writes” at all. It is “scratches, scrapes, furrows.” Writing entered the verb afterwards, once there was something to scratch a mark into.

You’ll want to know — five families, one picture

Now the striking part. Ask what “write” meant before it meant writing, and the same answer comes back from languages that never borrowed it from each other:

- Sanskrit लिखति — to **scratch**.
- Latin **scribere** — to **incise, cut**. English took **scribe, script, describe, manuscript** from it.
- Greek **gráphein** — to **scratch, carve**; behind **graph** and every **-graphy**. It is genuinely cousin to English **carve**.
- Old English **writan** — to **score, cut**; that is English **write** itself.

These are **four different roots**, not one worn four ways. Nobody handed this metaphor around. Four peoples with wax, stone, bark and bone each looked at their sharp tool and named the act after the damage it did. Hindi’s verb is one of them, and it kept the older sense honestly enough that *likhati* still glosses as “scrapes.”

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi likhtā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi likhtī hūmī*]
- Say it: the chapter in one breath — *mairi sochtā hūmī*, *mairi samajhtā hūmī*, *mairi parhtā hūmī*, *mairi likhtā hūmī*; then the same four as a woman, in *-tī*
- Say it: spell out मेरा नाम, the two words you first assembled by hand — म, the *e-mātrā* above it, र, the *ā*-tail; then न, ā, म — and finish with *mairi likhtā hūmī*
- Say it: *likhati*, *scribere*, *gráphein*, *writan* — and the one meaning all four started from (to scratch)

Before you move on

What did *likhati* mean first? (**To scratch.**) Are Sanskrit *likh-*, Latin *scribere* and English *write* one root or four? (**Four** — the picture is shared, the word is not.) Run the chapter's four verbs in the *māni* ... *hūni* frame. (*Sochtā, samajhtā, paṛhtā, likhtā.*)

Chapter 35

Taking, Asking, Helping — and Liking

35.1 लेना (lenā) — “to take,” a verb that lost a consonant

Four verbs of the mind are behind you. This chapter puts your hands back in the world — starting with the shortest verb in it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

लेना (lenā) = “**to take**.” Two syllables, and one of the most-used verbs in the language. Stem ले-: मैं लेता हूँ (m.) / मैं लेती हूँ (f.); आप लेते हैं. It reaches further than English “take”. Offered a drink, a Hindi speaker answers मैं पानी लेता हूँ — “I’ll have water,” the same lenā. It pairs with its opposite in the fixed phrase लेन-देन (len-den), “**taking and giving**” — Hindi’s word for dealings, transactions, business between people.

You’ll want to know — the consonant that fell out

लेना looks too short to have a history. It has a long one. Sanskrit’s verb was लभते (labhate) — “**takes, obtains, receives**.” Through Prakrit lahaī the **-bh-** thinned to a breath and then vanished, and the two vowels left behind fused into the single ले- you now say. Almost the whole word eroded.

The proof is sitting in Hindi’s own vocabulary. लाभ (lābh) — “**profit, gain, benefit**” — was borrowed back from Sanskrit later, straight out of the books, so it never went through that erosion. Verb and noun are the same word at two different ages: one worn smooth by mouths, one preserved on the shelf.

Further out, the standard comparison lines *labh-* up with Greek **lam-bánein**, “to take” — and English quietly holds three of its descendants: a **syllable** is letters “taken together”; **epilepsy** is “a seizing upon”; so is **catalepsy**.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi letā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi letī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: accept a drink — *mairi pānī letā hūmī*; then a meal — *mairi roṭī letā hūmī*. Object first, verb last, as always
- *Say it*: *pānī* and what it literally means (the drinkable thing), then *roṭī*
- *Say it*: *lenā* and *lābh* one after the other — the same Sanskrit verb, worn down and preserved

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit verb is *lenā*, and which consonant did it lose? (लभते *labhate*; the **-bh-**.) Which Hindi noun still shows that consonant, and why? (लाभ — borrowed back from Sanskrit, so it never eroded.) Say “I’ll have water.” (*Mairi pānī letā / letī hūmī*.)

35.2 पूछना (pūchnā) — “to ask,” and the reason English says “pray”

You have been asking questions since chapter two. Here, at last, is the verb for doing it.

The letters in this word

प (*pa*) with the long ू hanging beneath it → पू (*pū*); then छ (*cha*), the breathy pair of *ca*; then ना (*nā*) → पू · छ · ना.

The *ū* is genuinely long, and छ takes a puff of air, one degree heavier than the च in *sochnā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पूछना (*pūchnā*) = “to ask,” in the sense of asking a **question**. Stem पूछ-: मैं पूछता हूँ (m.) / मैं पूछती हूँ (f.); आप पूछते हैं.
 You already own a question — कितने साल के हो, “how many years are you of.” Now you can name the act itself: मैं उम्र पूछता हूँ, “I ask (someone’s) age.” The thing asked about sits in front of the verb, where every object has gone.

You’ll want to know — asking a person, asking a god

Behind पूछना stands Sanskrit पृच्छति (*pr̥cchati*, “asks”), and behind that a reconstructed root *prek-*, “to ask.” This one paid out generously across the family:

- Latin **precārī**, “to beg, to entreat” — English **pray**, **prayer**, **deprecate**, **imprecation**.
- Latin **precārius**, “held only so long as another allows” — English **precarious**. A precarious thing is one you keep by asking.
- German **fragen**, Dutch **vragen** — everyday “to ask” to this day.

English is the odd one out, instructively. Its own inherited cousin, Old English **frignan**, died out, and **ask** comes from somewhere else entirely — so the *prek-* word survived in English only in its religious clothes. Saying मैं पूछता हूँ, you use the verb English kept for **praying**, because asking a person and asking a god were once one act with one name.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *maini pūchtā hūni* · (f.): *maini pūchtī hūni*]
- *Say it*: the chapter-19 question, then name what you just did — *kitne sāl ke ho? ... maini umr pūchtā hūni*
- *Say it*: *maini pūchtā hūni*, then *maini letā hūni* — I ask, I take
- *Say it*: *pūchnā*, then **pray**, **precarious**, **fragen** — one root, three destinations

Before you move on

Which English verb is *pūchnā*’s true cousin — *ask* or *pray*? (**Pray** — *ask* is unrelated.) What does *precarious* literally describe? (Something **held only by asking**.) Say “I ask (someone’s) age.” (*Maimi umr pūchtā / pūchtī hūmī.*)

35.3 मदद करना (madad karnā) — “to help,” and the machine that builds it

This one is not a verb. It is a noun with a verb attached — and once you spot the join, you can build hundreds more.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मदद (*madad*) is a **noun**: “**help, aid**.” On its own it does nothing. Bolt करना (*karnā*, “to do”) on the end and you have the verb: मदद करना, literally “**to do help**.”

Only करना ever conjugates. The noun sits still:

- मैं मदद करता हूँ (m.) / मैं मदद करती हूँ (f.) — “I help.”
- आप मदद करते हैं — “you (resp.) help.”

This is the **conjunct verb**, and you have already used two without being told: काम करना, “to do work” = to work; and माफ़ कीजिए, “please do forgiveness” = sorry. One join, three verbs.

You’ll want to know — a stretched-out hand, and why the pattern matters

मदद is Arabic **madad**, on the root م-د-د (*m-d-d*), “**to stretch out, to extend**.” Help, in Arabic, is a thing **extended** toward you — the picture English reaches for when it *extends* a hand. It came into Hindi through **Persian**, the same road as उम्र (age) and माफ़ (forgiven).

State the gap plainly: English inherited **nothing** from *m-d-d*, and English **help** is a Germanic word unrelated to any of this. The picture is shared; the word is not.

Now why this matters more than one verb. A borrowed noun cannot be conjugated — Hindi would have to bend a foreign word through its own

endings. With करना it never has to: the loan stays a frozen noun and native grammar does the work. That is how Hindi swallowed centuries of Persian and Arabic vocabulary without disturbing its verb system at all.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi madad kartā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi madad kartī hūmī*]
- Say it: the three joins in a row — *kām karnā*, *māf karnā*, *madad karnā*; hear that only the second word ever moves
- Say it: *mairi pūchtā hūmī*, then *mairi madad kartā hūmī* — I ask, I help
- Say it: what *m-d-d* means underneath *madad* (to stretch out, extend)

Before you move on

Which half of *madad karnā* takes the endings? (करना — the noun never changes.) Name two conjunct verbs you had already used. (काम करना; माफ़ कीजिए.) Why does this pattern let Hindi borrow so freely? (The loan **stays a noun**; native *karnā* carries the grammar.)

35.4 पसंद (pasand) — Hindi does not like things; things please Hindi

Every verb so far let you be the one doing something. This last one takes that away.

You'll want to know — मुझे, the shape of “to me”

मुझे (*mujhe*) = “to me.” It is what मैं (“I”) becomes when the sentence will not let you be its subject. *Mujhe* is not “I.”

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

मुझे रोटी पसंद है = “I like bread” — or, taken apart: मुझे (“to me”) + रोटी (“bread”) + पसंद (“pleasing”) + है (“is”). “To me, bread is pleasing.” रोटी is the **subject**, and that is what है agrees with. You are only the person it happens to. Hindi has no “I like bread” with *I* in front.

Two languages walked here alone: Spanish **me gusta el café** (“to me, the coffee pleases”) and Italian **mi piace**. Those two are close cousins; Hindi is not, and nobody borrowed it. Two families, one decision — liking happens **to** you.

You’ll want to know — a Persian word doing a verb’s job

Because **पसंद is not a verb**. It is **Persian** — from پسندیدن (*pasandīdan*, “to approve, to find pleasing”) — and it entered Hindi as a noun and adjective, “**liked, one’s choice**.” A non-verb cannot carry the person doing the liking, so the grammar put them elsewhere: मुझे.

It came by the Persian road that also gave you शाम (evening) — and see what these two chapters have shown. Hindi’s verbs of the mind (*sochnā, samajhnā, parhnā, likhnā*) are inherited Indo-Aryan to a word, while *madad* and *pasand* — helping and liking — are borrowed. Thinking stayed home; the social vocabulary travelled.

For an active “like”, Hindi uses last lesson’s join: पसंद करना, “to do liking,” nearer to “I choose, I prefer.” For everyday liking, मुझे ... पसंद है.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mujhe roti pasand hai*, then the Hindi meaning — “to me, bread is pleasing”
- swap the thing, leaving *mujhe ... pasand hai* untouched — *mujhe pānī pasand hai* · *mujhe kuttā pasand hai* · *mujhe shām pasand hai*
- the chapter end to end — *maimi letā hūmī, maimi pūchtā hūmī, maimi madad kartā hūmī, mujhe roti pasand hai*
- *pasand karnā* beside *madad karnā* — one join, twice

Before you move on

In *mujhe roti pasand hai*, what is the subject? (रोटी — which is why it is *hai*.) What part of speech is *pasand*, and from where? (A **noun/adjective**, from **Persian** — not a verb.) Say “I like the dog,” then what it literally means. (*Mujhe kuttā pasand hai* — “to me, dog is pleasing.”)

Devanagari — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a”**: क = ka, न = na, म = ma.
2. **A vowel sign (*mātrā*) changes that vowel**: ा = ā (का kā), ि = i (written before, read after), े = e (के ke), and ि ु ू ै ौ for ī, u, ū, ai, o, au.
3. **A *halant* (ँ) removes the built-in vowel**: क् = bare k. A vowel-less consonant leans onto the next as a **conjunct**: स् + त → स्त (st), न् + य → न्य (ny).

Independent vowels (word-initial)

अ a · आ ā · इ i · ई ī · उ u · ऊ ū · ए e · ऐ ai · ओ o · औ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration** distinguishes letters: क k / ख kh, त t / थ th, द d / ध dh — the “h” is a real puff.
- **Retroflex** (ट ढ ण) vs. **dental** (त द न): tongue curled back vs. on the teeth.
- **Nukta** (a dot below) marks Perso-Arabic/English sounds: ज़ z, फ़ f, क़ q.

The two vocabularies

Many everyday ideas have two Hindi words — a **Sanskrit** one, often formal (*dhanyavād, namaste*), and a **Perso-Arabic** one, often everyday (*shukriyā, alvidā*). The lessons trace which is which.